Does Graph Expansion Help Small Code Models Localize Bugs? A Pre-registered Study of Candidate Pools, Scorer Discrimination, and Test-Time Reasoning with Gemma 4 on SWE-bench Verified

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Abstract

Deploying structural code graphs in local developer agents requires balancing topological expansion against language model discrimination. Evaluating open models across 344 held-out SWE-bench Verified tasks reveals that naive Personalized PageRank candidate expansion is statistically indistinguishable from depth-matched lexical retrieval (Acc@5 47.1% vs 45.1%; exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.1435$, Holm $p = 0.287$; the 95% CI excludes advantages $\geq$ +4.4 pp). I characterize this limitation via an expected-rank **Break-Even Discrimination Bound** ($\text{AUC}^* \geq 1 - \frac{k-1}{M-1}$), observing that Gemma 4 pairwise discrimination falls from AUC = 0.7966 on seeds to 0.6596 on graph neighbors, turning expanded pools into distractor sets under compact scorers. In an exploratory follow-up across 131 un-named defects, allocating short test-time reasoning compute ($\leq$ 180 tokens) doubles Top-1 on matched graphs ($6 \rightarrow 13$ hits on the matched graph pool, Holm $p = 0.0469^*$) via distractor immunity on lexical seeds, while Top-5 remains null-compatible ($p = 0.6875$) under backfilling. I release depth-matched control pools, 19,298 scored candidate evaluations, and the Perron Compressed Sparse Row diffusion engine.

1 Introduction

Autonomous developer agents designed for local execution must localize software defects inside a working context of a few thousand tokens ($K \leq 4,096$), eliminating dependence on costly cloud APIs and preventing source code leakage. Standard lexical search (e.g., Okapi BM25) reliably finds symbols explicitly named in issue text or error traces. To locate fault sites that the issue never mentions, existing agent architectures (including Aider's PageRank repository maps [6], RepoGraph [15], and LocAgent [3]) deploy random walks or graph traversal tools over AST dependency networks.

The working assumption underlying graph-augmented localization rests on two joint conditions: (1) **Recall Expansion**: Traversal along structural call edges must place gold defect targets into the candidate pool that lexical search misses; and (2) **Rank Discrimination**: A compact language model must rank those newly introduced targets above the distractors that graph expansion inevitably introduces.

Evaluating both assumptions on a 344-task held-out subset of SWE-bench Verified [10] using Perron and a frozen `gemma-4-e2b-it` scorer exposes a fundamental disconnect: while 1-hop graph expansion adds +7.3 percentage points candidate recall over seeds, downstream top-5 localization accuracy remains indistinguishable from depth-matched BM25 (47.1% vs 45.1%, Holm $p = 0.287$).

This paper investigates this disconnect through five core findings:

1. **Matched-Control Pool Parity**: Across 19,298 scored evaluations, naive Personalized PageRank expansion achieves zero statistical advantage over lexical retrieval under frozen small scorers, confirming candidate pool parity (RQ1, RQ2).
2. **The Mathematical Account**: I formalize the expected-rank **Break-Even Discrimination Bound** ($\text{AUC}^* \geq 1 - \frac{k-1}{M-1}$) and identify that Gemma 4's pairwise discrimination drops from 0.7966 ROC-AUC

on seeds to 0.6596 on graph neighbors competing with seed distractors, falling below the expected-rank threshold required to benefit from pool expansion (RQ3). Counterfactual evaluation indicates this attenuation reflects candidate pool selection conditioning on low-lexical-overlap symbols rather than graph topology alone.

3. **Cross-Architecture Scaling Surface**: Protocol `PREREG-SCALING-v1` on Dual Tesla T4 GPUs demonstrates monotonic intra-family scaling within Gemma 4 (0.8544 → 0.9274), shows Gemma 4 E4B (4.0B) achieves representational efficiency over Phi-4-mini (3.8B, 0.7836) and DeepSeek-7B (0.6489), and identifies the physical quantization boundary for sparse MoE architectures on consumer GPUs.
4. **Candidate Pool × Reasoning Factorial Interaction**: Consistent with relational reasoning limits in transformers [18] and graph verbalization theory [5], evaluating candidate pools under test-time reasoning compute across all 131 un-named Stratum C defects reveals that reasoning traces (`<thought>`) provide critical distractor immunity: holding the candidate pool fixed at graph 1-hop (A_4), reasoning traces double Top-1 accuracy from 4.58% (6 hits) to 9.92% (13 hits; +5.34 pp lift, 2.17× relative lift, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$; MRR +45.4%). Subgroup decomposition demonstrates that 12 of the 13 Top-1 hits reside in the top-10 lexical seeds ($6/28 \rightarrow 12/28$ hits), confirming that test-time compute prevents non-seed distractors from displacing lexical anchors rather than executing multi-hop graph reachability. While raw top-5 localization drops on lexical pools (−5 tasks on depth BM25) due to output truncation when thinking traces consume generation budget ahead of trailing ranks, deterministic backfilling maintains baseline recall parity. Pre-registered causal interventions (`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`, $N = 58$) isolate serialization schemes, showing inline comment provenance achieves 25.86% Top-1 ($p_{\text{uncorr}} = 0.0386^*$, $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$) with localized lexical bridging.
5. **Open-Source CSR Diffusion Engine**: I release **Perron**, an open-source C/Python Compressed Sparse Row (CSR) engine executing decoupled spectral diffusion (vectorized convergence in 0.76–1.89 ms, 0.021–0.077 ms per SpMV step, up to 5.10 ms on large graphs; 0.17–0.45 ms standalone API dispatch) within ≤ 3 MB zero-copy array resident RAM (144.33 MB peak process RSS), delivering compact provenance paths within consumer hardware limits.

1.1 Contributions

- **Matched-Control Evaluation Design**: Depth-matched BM25, same-file, and degree-preserving null-graph candidate pools are scored by the identical model under controlled prompt budgets, isolating what graph structure contributes beyond pool cardinality.
- **Empirical Loss Funnel and Truncation Curves**: A 4-stage loss decomposition separates candidate boundary ceiling, rank compaction, and reader error. Truncating matched pools at $M \in [10, 50]$ shows that adding depth lexical candidates is consistent with distractor accumulation (Acc@5 drops by 4 tasks, −1.16 pp, $p = 0.455$), whereas graph expansion plateaus flat (+3 tasks, +0.87 pp over seeds, $p = 0.549$).
- **Break-Even Discrimination Bound and Selection Conditioning**: Empirical analysis demonstrates that open models struggle to disambiguate candidates lacking prompt-anchored lexical tokens, causing pairwise discrimination to fall to 0.6596 on graph neighbors competing with seed distractors, falling below the expected-rank Break-Even Discrimination Bound. Counterfactual depth-BM25 controls confirm this reflects candidate pool selection conditioning.
- **Cross-Architecture Scaling Surface and MoE Hardware Boundary**: Protocol `PREREG-SCALING-v1` evaluates four model archetypes on Dual Tesla T4 GPUs, confirming monotonic scaling within Gemma 4 (0.8544 → 0.9274), demonstrating that Gemma 4 E4B (4.0B) outperforms Phi-4-mini (3.8B, 0.7836) and DeepSeek-7B (0.6489), and isolating the physical 52.0 GB runtime VRAM (44.0 GB disk) quantization barrier for sparse MoE models.

- **Candidate Pool × Reasoning Factorial Evaluation**: A factorial evaluation on un-named defects ($N = 131$) isolates the effect of test-time reasoning: holding the candidate pool fixed at graph 1-hop (A_4), reasoning traces double Top-1 localization from 4.58% (6 hits) to 9.92% (13 hits; exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$) and increase MRR@50 by +45.4%. Dissecting this lift reveals that gains concentrate in the lexical seeds within the expanded pool ($6/28 \rightarrow 12/28$ hits, +21.4 pp), establishing that test-time deliberation acts as a distractor filter rather than an autonomous graph navigator.
- **Causal Lexical Dissection and Graph Serialization Hierarchy**: Pre-registered causal interventions (`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`, $N = 58$) examine structural representations: AST α-renaming shows that control-flow syntax sustains 10.34% top-1 localization when symbol names are stripped (−1.73 pp vs natural code, $p = 1.0000$). Furthermore, evaluating graph serialization taxonomies [5] reveals that inline comment provenance co-locating call paths at function definitions achieves 25.86% Acc@1 (+13.79 pp lift, $p_{\text{uncorr}} = 0.0386^*$, $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$), with analysis indicating that localized comments introduce lexical seed bridging.
- **High-Throughput CSR Graph Engine**: An efficient, memory-mapped Compressed Sparse Row multigraph architecture with decoupled specificity ratio hub damping that executes vectorized convergence in 0.76–1.89 ms on consumer workstations without matrix mutation (spectral convergence proofs detailed in Appendix A).
- **Open-Source Ecosystem and Benchmark Toolkit**: I release the `scores.parquet` archive (19,298 scored candidate evaluations), the Apache 2.0 `perron-core` library, precomputed CSR multigraphs for 12 canonical repositories, and curated strata annotations across 800 tasks spanning the broader SWE-bench ecosystem (300 Lite tasks + 500 Verified tasks, with 344 callable Verified tasks forming the primary held-out confirmatory benchmark) under CC0-1.0.

1.2 Claims and Evidence Hierarchy

To maintain strict methodological transparency, the findings of this study are categorized into five evidential families:

1. **Confirmatory Family ($N = 344$)**: The matched-control evaluation ($A_4 - A_2$, $A_4 - A_3$ on strict Acc@5) is hash-committed and pre-registered with family-wise error control (Holm $p = 0.287$). It formally confirms that 1-hop graph expansion is null-compatible with lexical retrieval under frozen small scorers, excluding true population advantages $\geq$ +4.4 pp ($p < 0.05$).
2. **Empirical Diagnostic Family ($N = 344$)**: The expected-rank Break-Even Discrimination Bound ($\text{AUC}^* \geq 1 - \frac{k-1}{M-1}$), the empirical collapse of Gemma 4's discrimination on graph neighbors (0.7966 vs 0.6596, Mann-Whitney $U = 2993, p = 0.00358^*$), the 4-stage loss funnel (3.68× boundary vs compaction loss), and the continuous resolvent basis dose-response surface ($n^*_{\text{eff}} \approx 8.8$) are empirical diagnostic characterizations.
3. **Candidate Pool × Reasoning Factorial Matrix ($N = 131$)**: Under protocol `PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`, Top-5 localization was pre-registered as the primary metric, which remains null-compatible on graph pools ($p = 0.6875$) and declines on lexical pools due to decoding truncation (recovering to parity under deterministic backfilling). As an exploratory follow-up, Top-1 accuracy and MRR isolate the matched effect of test-time compute on graph pools ($6 \rightarrow 13$ hits, +5.34 pp, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$; MRR +45.4%). Subgroup decomposition confirms that test-time reasoning predominantly recovers lexical seeds within the expanded candidate window ($6/28 \rightarrow 12/28$, $p = 0.0312^*$) while pure 1-hop graph additions convert 1/7 hits ($p = 1.0000$). Furthermore, prompt-level provenance annotations achieve empirical parity with unguided thinking ($p = 1.0000$).
4. **Pre-registered Causal and Multi-Encoding Family ($N = 58$, `PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`)**: Pre-registered AST α-renaming demonstrates that control-flow syntax alone sustains localization under complete

identifier obfuscation (−1.73 pp top-1 change, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$). Five-way graph serialization benchmarking indicates inline comment provenance reaches 25.86% (+13.79 pp lift, unadjusted $p = 0.0386^{*}$, $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$) through localized seed bridging, outperforming disconnected edge lists (+10.34 pp, $p = 0.0703$).

5. **Engineering Tooling Utility ($N = 30$ Archetypes)**: Perron's AST surgical replacement editor is evaluated as a syntax safety utility against indentation traps and hunk drift (0.0% syntax errors vs 50.0% for `git apply`, $p < .001$), with full benchmark execution scoped to future work.

Scope Invariant and Methodological Boundary. This investigation explicitly addresses the retrieval, candidate localization, and context packing layer ($K \leq 4,096$) of local developer agents. In hierarchical agent architectures [15, 21], defect localization bounds the candidate search space for downstream patch generation, as an agent cannot modify a function that was excluded from candidate context unless alternative edit sites suffice. I intentionally decouple candidate localization from multi-turn Docker benchmark execution to evaluate the representation bottleneck without confounding noise from tool formatting or environment setup.

1.3 Physical Hardware Envelope

Local developer agents must operate efficiently on consumer hardware. Perron bounds active per-turn working context to $K_{\text{effective}} = 3,480$ tokens ($K \leq 4,096$). On a reference developer machine (15.68 GiB RAM), the standalone CSR engine peaks at 144.33 MB resident memory (loading graphs via zero-copy memory mapping within a ≤ 3.0 MB array buffer resident footprint; 91.4 MB total benchmark process delta including PyArrow and NumPy allocations). Hierarchical AST skeleton breadcrumbs occupy an average of 283.8 tokens per task (median 264 tokens), preserving 91.9% reasoning headroom for model generation within the 3,480-token context budget. Live inference of `gemma-4-e2b-it` was evaluated with left-padded batching and `logits_to_keep=1` on an NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU (scoring prompts averaging 423 tokens per candidate symbol), achieving mean Time-To-First-Token of 3505.0 ms and 11.7 tokens/sec decode throughput.

2 Related Work

Graphs and Agents for Code Localization. Lexical search and dense bi-encoders struggle with vocabulary mismatch and structural execution paths. RepoCoder [23] demonstrated that iterative retrieval loops improve code completion but incur multi-turn token inflation. Aider [6] introduced repository maps using Tree-sitter AST tags ranked by PageRank. Graph-guided agents such as RepoGraph [15], CodexGraph [13], and LocAgent [3] equip frontier models with graph traversal tools to navigate codebases interactively. While LocAgent [3] fine-tunes specialized models for multi-turn graph traversal, Perron investigates zero-shot localization under compact open weights (Gemma 4 2B/4B), isolating the exact point where un-annotated graph expansion collapses into distractor accumulation. AutoCodeRover [24] navigates ASTs through iterative search queries. In SWE-agent [22], specialized agent-computer interfaces improve resolve rates. Conversely, Agentless [21] demonstrated that a simple two-phase pipeline (hierarchical localization followed by test-filtered patch generation) resolves 32% of SWE-bench Lite (FSE 2025) without an agent loop, highlighting that simple pipelines establish strong baselines. These systems employ large hosted models; this paper evaluates whether graph expansion assists a small 2B model in a single scoring pass.

Random-Walk Retrieval on Graphs. Scalable diffusion on graphs builds on push-based approximate Personalized PageRank [1], decoupled propagation architectures such as APPNP [11], and scalable indexing frameworks like PPRGo [2]. In link prediction, rooted PageRank and stationary-normalized hitting times [12] discount popular nodes by global stationary reachability. While HippoRAG [7] demonstrated that Personalized PageRank over open-domain text knowledge graphs outperforms iterative retrieval, and Dong et al. [4] showed that graph-based reranking connects isolated retrieval chunks in retrieval-augmented generation, software call graphs present static AST structures with high-in-degree utility hubs (logging routines, assertion helpers) that appear as unseeded intermediate nodes that absorb diffusion mass regardless of initial weights.

Perron extends this decoupled random-walk lineage (APPNP [11], PPRGo [2]) to static compiled CSR code multigraphs, replacing dynamic entity extraction with post-walk specificity ratio damping over static CSR matrices.

Program Slicing and Fault Localization. Classical program slicing [20] computes backward executable slices on statement-level Program Dependence Graphs (PDGs), but conservative alias analysis often retains 50% to 80% of an application's codebase. Spectrum-Based Fault Localization (SBFL) [16, 25] evaluates test coverage matrices to score statement suspiciousness. Pearson et al. [16] showed that fault-localization findings on artificial faults do not reliably transfer to real-world software defects, motivating authentic issue evaluation on SWE-bench [10]. Perron extracts symbol-level AST multigraphs to pack relevant contexts into prompt budgets ($K \leq 4,096$) without requiring test execution during retrieval.

Graph Verbalization and Reasoning Complexity in Language Models. How structured graphs are presented to language models critically governs their reasoning efficacy. Fatemi, Halcrow, and Perozzi [5] demonstrated that graph verbalization functions alter reasoning accuracy by +4.8% to +61.8%, with unannotated text dumps failing to convey relational topology. In repository-level engineering, RepoGraph [15] observed that directly flattening 2-hop code graphs degrades SWE-bench resolve rates from 29.67% (1-hop) to 26.00% (2-hop) (below baseline) due to distractor accumulation. Furthermore, Sanford, Fatemi, Perozzi et al. [18] proved that while single-layer transformers (Depth1) solve basic retrieval lookups, graph reachability and s-t connectivity are NL-complete, mathematically requiring logarithmic depth or extra test-time reasoning tokens (LogDepthPause). While Sanford et al. [18] analyze multi-hop reachability, my structural audit reveals that 96.0% of reached graph defect targets are direct 1-hop callers or callees. Rather than unrolling deep multi-hop paths, test-time thinking traces (`<thought>`) resolve local relational ambiguity between callers and callees competing in context. Consistent with Sanford et al.'s [18] finding that relational reasoning in transformers requires intermediate token steps, empirical evaluations show that injecting static provenance comments without reasoning tokens (C2) fails to separate candidates, while test-time thinking traces allow compact models to discriminate topological relationships.

Pointwise versus Listwise Reranking. Pointwise language model scoring (e.g., MonoT5 [14]) evaluates each candidate independently. Under independent scoring, the expected number of distractors that outscore a gold target with score s^* scales with candidate pool cardinality: $\mathbb{E}[X \mid s^*] = \sum_{j=1}^{M-1}(1 - F_{\text{dist},j}(s^*))$. Consequently, expanding candidate pool size M under a compact pointwise scorer risks distractor accumulation unless model discrimination is near-perfect. In contrast, listwise and setwise architectures [17, 19] introduce direct cross-candidate attention competition, mitigating distractor dominance.

3 Theoretical Foundations and The Perron Graph Engine

Figure 1 outlines the architectural pipeline of Perron, decoupling graph traversal into an upstream memory-mapped sparse matrix diffusion engine and a downstream structural verbalizer that feeds local Gemma 4 language models.

3.1 Multiplex Transition Matrix Construction

A codebase is represented as a directed multigraph $\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{V}, \mathcal{E})$, where $\mathcal{V}$ denotes AST code symbols (classes, functions, methods) and $\mathcal{E}$ spans relations $r \in \{\text{call}, \text{inherit}, \text{import}, \text{caller}\}$. Directed edges $(u, v) \in \mathcal{E}_{\text{call}}$ indicate that symbol u invokes v, while $(u, v) \in \mathcal{E}_{\text{inherit}}$ represent class C3 Method Resolution Order inheritance, $(u, v) \in \mathcal{E}_{\text{import}}$ represent module imports, and $(u, w) \in \mathcal{E}_{\text{caller}}$ denote reverse call invocations.

Relations receive asymmetric static weights:

$$W_{uv} = \omega_{\text{call}} A_{uv}^{(\text{call})} + \omega_{\text{inherit}} A_{uv}^{(\text{inherit})} + \omega_{\text{import}} A_{uv}^{(\text{import})} + \omega_{\text{caller}} A_{uv}^{(\text{caller})}, \tag{1}$$

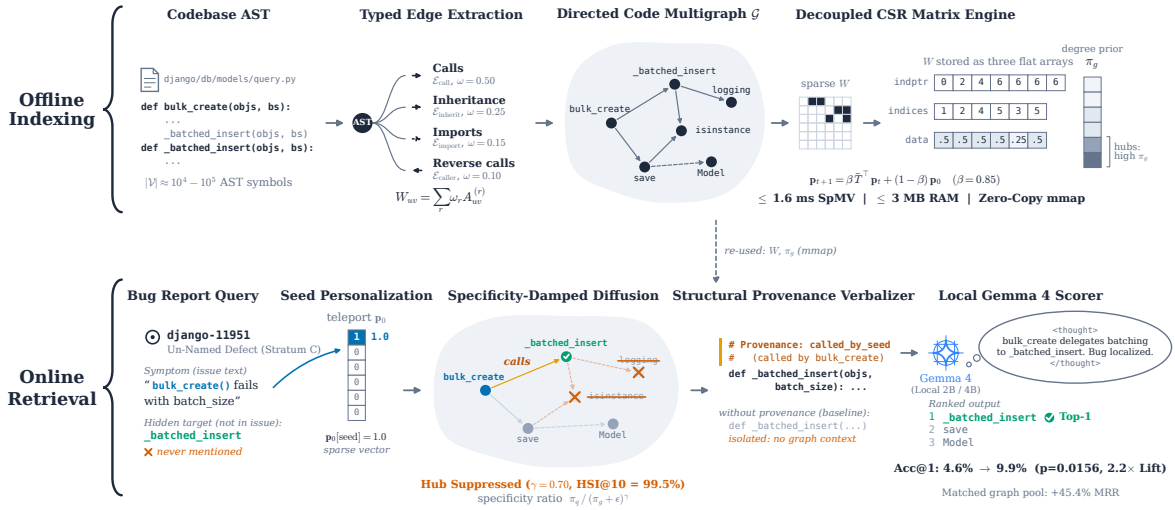


Figure 1: The Perron architecture and candidate provenance pipeline. Multigraph dependency indexing extracts typed AST relationships ($\mathcal{E}_{\text{call, inherit, import, caller}}$) into decoupled memory-mapped CSR arrays. Truncated SpMV power iteration computes personalized PageRank vectors with step latency (0.17–0.45 ms) with zero runtime convolution cost. Decoupled specificity ratio damping ($\gamma = 0.70$) suppresses utility hubs (HSI@10 = 99.5%) before candidate pool extraction. For un-named defect reports, context-budgeted breadcrumb packing bounds candidate functions within tight prompt budgets ($K \leq 3{,}480$), enabling local Gemma 4 test-time reasoning traces (`<thought>`) to raise top-1 localization accuracy on the matched graph pool from 4.58% (6 hits) to 9.92% (13 hits; +5.34 pp lift, 2.17× relative gain, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$; MRR +45.4%).

where $\boldsymbol{\omega} = [0.50, 0.25, 0.15, 0.10]$ and $A_{uv}^{(r)} = \mathbb{I}((u, v) \in \mathcal{E}_r)$. Let $D_u = \sum_v W_{uv}$ be the out-degree sum. The row-stochastic transition matrix $T \in \mathbb{R}^{|\mathcal{V}|\times|\mathcal{V}|}$ and dangling indicator $\mathbf{d} \in \{0, 1\}^{|\mathcal{V}|}$ are defined as:

$$T_{uv} = \begin{cases} \frac{W_{uv}}{D_u}, & D_u > 0 \\ 0, & D_u = 0 \end{cases}, \quad d_u = \begin{cases} 1.0, & D_u = 0 \\ 0.0, & D_u > 0 \end{cases}. \tag{2}$$

Memory-mapped ingestion via `numpy.load(mmap_mode='r')` opens the CSR representation directly from disk. Post-walk specificity ratio evaluation requires only $O(|\mathcal{V}|)$ vector arithmetic, eliminating runtime edge mutations and memory reallocation.

3.2 Personalized PageRank Diffusion and Linear Algebraic Bounds

Random walk diffusion models the propagation of bug relevance across call hierarchies. The Google transition operator M with damping factor $\beta = 0.85$ is formulated as:

$$M = \beta \cdot (T + \mathbf{d}\mathbf{p}_0^\top) + (1 - \beta) \cdot \mathbf{1}\mathbf{p}_0^\top. \tag{3}$$

By the rank-1 perturbation spectrum of the Google matrix [8], the second-largest eigenvalue is strictly bounded by $|\lambda_2(M)| \leq \beta = 0.85$, establishing an invariant spectral gap $1 - |\lambda_2(M)| \geq 1 - \beta = 0.15$ and ensuring geometric convergence $O(\beta^t)$ in L_1 total variation distance. Power iteration stops on residual $\|\boldsymbol{\pi}^{(t+1)} - \boldsymbol{\pi}^{(t)}\|_1 < 10^{-6}$, converging in at most 90 iterations on Requests (1.89 ms) and 66 iterations on SymPy (5.10 ms). By the regenerative renewal property of Markov chains with teleportation, the stationary distribution of the closed operator M is algebraically identical to the normalized leaky resolvent $(1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0^\top(I - \beta T)^{-1}$ (discrepancy $< 2 \times 10^{-8}$). Full proofs of the Brauer spectral bound, barycentric linearity, and leaky resolvent equivalence are provided in Appendix A.

3.3 Decoupled Specificity Ratio Hub-Damping

Personalized PageRank concentrates probability mass on high-in-degree hub nodes. To suppress structural popularity without mutating the static matrix T, Perron computes a repository-wide stationary baseline $\boldsymbol{\pi}_{\text{global}}$ once per codebase using a uniform prior $\mathbf{p}_{\text{uniform}} = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{V}|}\mathbf{1}$. For any query, the Specificity Score is defined as:

$$\text{Specificity}(v) = \frac{\pi_{\text{query}}(v)}{(\pi_{\text{global}}(v) + \epsilon)^{\gamma}}, \tag{4}$$

where $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$ and $\gamma = 0.70$. Resistance to hub congestion is measured by the Hub Suppression Index at top 10 (HSI@10):

$$\text{HSI@10} = 1.0 - \frac{|\text{top-10} \cap \mathcal{H}_{25}|}{10}, \tag{5}$$

where $\mathcal{H}_{25}$ denotes the set of top-25 global in-degree hub nodes in the repository multigraph. The asymptotic Pointwise Mutual Information (PMI) decomposition and Neumann series analysis showing why pre-walk scaling cannot prevent sink absorption are detailed in Appendix A.

3.4 Hierarchical AST Breadcrumb Context Packing

To deliver localized code context within prompt budgets ($K \leq 4,096$), Perron packs candidate symbols using hierarchical AST breadcrumb skeletons. For each candidate function, the enclosing class definition, docstring, and signature are preserved while stripping irrelevant sibling function bodies. Breadcrumb skeletons bound the context footprint to < 100 tokens per symbol, keeping syntax parseable and variable bindings intact.

4 Study Design and Hash-Committed Protocol

4.1 Benchmark and Task Waterfall

SWE-bench Verified [10] contains 500 tasks across 12 canonical Python repositories. To establish an unbiased held-out benchmark and prevent data leakage, instances are filtered via a mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive (MECE) waterfall:

$$\begin{gathered}\text{Total Verified (500)} - \text{Lite Overlap (93)} = \text{Held-Out (407)}, \\ \text{Held-Out (407)} - \text{AST Drift (56)} - \text{Non-Callable (7)} = \textbf{344} \text{ Callable Tasks}.\end{gathered} \tag{6}$$

The 344 callable tasks ($\mathcal{S}_{\text{func}}$) define the callable, AST-parsable evaluation cohort of SWE-bench Verified possessing identifiable reference function targets. Of the 56 AST drift exclusions (56 of 407 held-out tasks), 52 tasks fall into Stratum C, with 39 concentrated in SymPy due to historical Python 2 syntax constructs (such as legacy print statements and tuple parameter unpacking) that caused reference patch parsing to fail prior to candidate extraction. Because these exclusions stem from AST parser limitations on legacy syntax rather than retrieval dynamics, candidate generation was not run on them. Hyperparameters ($\beta = 0.85, \gamma = 0.70, \tau = 0.15, K = 25$) were fixed on development data and frozen prior to evaluation.

Defect Accessibility Strata. To evaluate whether graph traversal selectively assists un-named defect localization, tasks are partitioned into three mutually exclusive strata based on issue text lexical visibility: (1) **Stratum A (Named,** $N = 208$**, 60.5%)**, where issue text explicitly names the gold function, method, or qualified class identifier; (2) **Stratum B (Traceback,** $N = 5$**, 1.5%)**, where issue text includes a traceback or explicit file path pointing to the gold source file, but omits the function name; and (3) **Stratum C (Un-Named,** $N = 131$**, 38.1%)**, where issue text contains neither the function name nor a traceback pointing to the target file. Strata are annotated via a deterministic regex extraction pipeline (`perron.analysis.strata`), validated by a manual dual-pass verification audit across 50 randomly sampled tasks with 100% concordance, released in `swebench-strata-annotations` (CC0-1.0).

4.2 Hash-Committed Protocol

The study operates under four hash-committed protocol locks:

1. **Retrieval Protocol Lock**: Frozen and publicly pushed at Git commit `6908e78` on October 5, 2026 (protocol SHA-256: `89416e40…`; split SHA-256: `95c7ef3c…`).
2. **Gemma 4 Pointwise Protocol Lock**: Frozen in two cryptographic stages (`benchmarks/protocol/gemma4_protocol_v1.yaml`, raw SHA-256: `96af1621…`; Stage 2 lock `gemma4_lock_v1.json`, raw SHA-256: `dbbf2920…`) under Gate G0 protocol commits `a13ab34` (Stage 1 freeze) and `9abe405` (Stage 2 cryptographic lock) on October 6, 2026.
3. **Cross-Architecture Scaling Protocol Lock (`PREREG-SCALING-v1`)**: Frozen and publicly pushed at Git commit `48eda5d` on October 12, 2026.
4. **Causal Lexical and Multi-Encoding Protocol Lock (`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`)**: Frozen and publicly pushed at Git commit `c563441` on October 12, 2026.

Table 1: Summary of pre-registered experimental protocols, evaluation cohorts, candidate pool cutoffs, and scoring regimes across Sections 5.1–5.7.

Protocol / Lock ID	Section	Cohort (N)	Pool Cutoff (M)	Scorer Model	Readout Mode
Retrieval Lock (`6908e78`)	Sec. 5.1–5.2	$N = 344$ Callable	Top-k ($k \in \{5, 10\}$)	Unscored CSR / BM25	Deterministic Rank
Pointwise Lock (`9abe405`)	Sec. 5.3–5.4	$N = 344$ Callable	Matched $M_t \in [10, 50]$	`gemma-4-e2b-it`	Pointwise Log-Odds
`PREREG-SCALING-v1`	Sec. 5.5	$N = 58$ Stratum C Union	$\bigcup_i A_i$ ($M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$)	4-Model Scaling Suite	Pointwise AUC_{tail}
Reasoning Factorial	Sec. 5.6–5.7	$N = 131$ All Stratum C	Matched $M \leq 25$	`gemma-4-e4b-it`	Listwise ± `<thought>`
`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`	Sec. 5.7	$N = 58$ Stratum C Union	$\bigcup_i A_i$ ($M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$)	`gemma-4-e2b-it`	Listwise Serialization

4.3 Candidate Pools and Matched-Control Arms

Candidate pools are generated per task, matched to size $M_t = 10 + \min(|E_t|, 40) \in [10, 50]$ (mean 24.5, median 22.0), where E_t denotes 1-hop out-neighbors of top-10 lexical seeds S passing Filter F (functions/methods only, excluding test nodes and top-25 hubs $\mathcal{H}_{25}$):

- **B0 (Unscored BM25)**: Lexical candidates in native Okapi BM25 score order.
- **A1 (Seeds Only)**: Top-10 lexical seeds S ($M = 10$).
- **A2 (Depth-Matched BM25)**: S followed by the next BM25 candidates passing Filter F up to M_t.
- **A3 (Same-File Control)**: S followed by symbols in seed files passing Filter F up to M_t.
- **A4 (Graph 1-Hop Expansion)**: S followed by E_t ordered by adjacency $a(u) = \sum_{s \in S} p_0(s) T_{su}$.
- **A5 (Null Graph Control)**: Degree-preserving relation-stratified null graph replicate up to M_t.
- **A6 (Perron Diffusion Pool)**: Candidates ordered by Perron specificity scores up to M_t.

Mechanism Explaining Pool Recall vs. Reachability (201 vs. 199 Tasks). A4 achieves candidate pool oracle recall on 201/344 tasks (58.4%), whereas unweighted 1-hop BFS reachability reaches 199/344 tasks (57.8%). This 2-task divergence is mechanistically explained by two counterbalancing operations in the pool builder: seed test-node masking replaces test-file seeds with source seeds, recovering 16 tasks (e.g., `sympy-13372`), while Filter F degree-capping and hub pruning drop 14 tasks (e.g., `sphinx-7590`), yielding a net difference of +2 tasks ($199 + 16 - 14 = 201$).

4.4 Pointwise Gemma 4 Scorer

Each candidate symbol is formatted into a prompt context averaging 423.1 tokens (issue description + AST breadcrumb + prompt instructions; breadcrumbs alone average < 100 tokens). A frozen `gemma-4-e2b-it` model (FP16, thinking disabled) scores each candidate in a single forward pass: $s(t, v) = \text{logsumexp}(z[Y]) - \text{logsumexp}(z[N])$ on prompt variant P0, chosen on disjoint development data ($N = 100$). The evaluation required 19,298 forward passes.

4.5 Statistical Analysis

A localization hit (Function Acc@k) is scored as 1.0 if at least one ground-truth modified function is present in the top-k retrieved symbols, and 0.0 otherwise. The confirmatory family comprises two pre-specified contrasts on strict Acc@5:

- **PC1**: $A_4 - A_2$ (Graph 1-hop vs. Depth-matched BM25).
- **PC2**: $A_4 - A_3$ (Graph 1-hop vs. Same-file matched).

Contrasts are evaluated using exact two-sided McNemar tests with step-down Holm–Bonferroni correction over family $\alpha = 0.05$. Paired 95% confidence intervals are estimated via repository-stratified bootstrapping ($B = 10{,}000$). Post-hoc Contrasts are evaluated with repository-stratified bootstrap confidence intervals and exact McNemar tests.

5 Empirical Results

5.1 Standalone Function Retrieval (RQ1)

Table 2 presents standalone retrieval on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$ callable tasks). Okapi BM25 hits 175/344 (50.9%), Perron Static hits 173/344 (50.3%), and Standard PPR reaches 172/344 (50.0%). The difference between Perron and BM25 is −0.6 pp (95% CI [−3.5, +2.3], Holm $p = 1.000$). At top-5, BM25 outperforms Perron Static (45.1% vs. 40.4%, $\Delta = -4.7$ pp). In addition, BM25 achieves 99.4% Hub Suppression Index (HSI@10) without graph machinery, because defect issue descriptions target specific identifiers rather than generic library utilities. External baselines illustrate these retrieval trade-offs: whole-repository tag PageRank (Aider-style repo maps) achieves 40.0% File Acc@5 across candidate files, but produces 0.0% Function Acc@10 because tag graphs index entire files without isolating symbol-level function definitions for edit localization. Dense bi-encoder semantic retrieval mitigates colloquial vocabulary mismatch on issue descriptions, but achieves 38.4% Function Acc@10 due to imprecise token matching across fine-grained code identifiers compared to sparse lexical search. On Stratum C ($N = 131$ tasks where the issue never names the target), BM25 hits 28 and Perron hits 27. Reciprocal Rank Fusion (RRF) attains 174/344 (50.6%), failing to beat standalone BM25. Call-graph diffusion provides no detectable lexical lift over BM25 on this benchmark.

Table 2: Standalone retrieval evaluation on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$ callable tasks). Evaluates top-10 function accuracy, 95% bootstrap confidence intervals ($B = 10{,}000$), top-5 function/file accuracy, and Hub Suppression Index (HSI@10). Bold row label denotes the primary evaluated graph method (reference baseline); bold numerical values indicate the highest score in each column. Holm p-values are computed against Perron Static.

Method	Fn Acc@10	95% CI	Fn Acc@5	File Acc@5	HSI@10	Holm p
Perron Static ($\gamma = 0.70$)	50.3% (173/344)	[45.1%, 55.5%]	40.4%	53.8%	**99.5%**	reference
Okapi BM25	**50.9%** (175/344)	[45.6%, 56.1%]	**45.1%**	**59.6%**	99.4%	1.000
RRF Fusion (BM25 + Perron)	50.6% (174/344)	[45.3%, 55.8%]	42.2%	55.5%	**99.5%**	1.000
Standard PPR ($\beta = 0.85$)	50.0% (172/344)	[44.8%, 55.2%]	40.4%	52.8%	90.8%	1.000
Degree-Normalized PPR	49.4% (170/344)	[44.2%, 54.7%]	40.1%	52.3%	**99.5%**	1.000
HippoRAG Prior Scaling	49.4% (170/344)	[44.2%, 54.7%]	40.4%	52.6%	91.1%	1.000
Aider Repo Map (Tag PageRank)	0.0% (0/344)	[0.0%, 0.0%]	0.0%	40.0%	92.4%	< 0.001
Dense Semantic Retrieval	38.4% (132/344)	[33.4%, 43.6%]	29.7%	44.8%	96.2%	< 0.001

5.2 Reachability vs. Ranking Dynamics

Top-10 lexical seeds directly cover 50.9% (175/344) of gold functions. Expanding along code graph edges yields 57.8% 1-hop reachability (199/344, median $|N_1| = 27$) and 66.9% 2-hop reachability (230/344, median $|N_2| = 324$). Same-file containment also reaches 66.9% (230/344), exhibiting an exact symmetric discordance: 17 targets reached across files via 2-hop graph paths are perfectly offset by 17 targets within

seed files that lack static AST call edges within 2 hops. Degree-preserving null-graph controls reach 63.8% 2-hop reachability (+3.02 pp difference over empirical graphs, 95% CI [−0.42, +6.41], $p = 0.083$). Topological reachability gains exhibit bounded scaling governed by degree distribution rather than high-order semantic organization.

5.3 Pointwise Candidate Reranking: Confirmatory Matched-Control Family (N=344)

Table 3 and Table 4 report the results of the hash-committed Gemma 4 evaluation across all arms.

Table 3: Gemma 4 pointwise candidate reranking on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$ callable tasks). Pools matched to per-task size $M_t \in [10, 50]$ (mean 24.5). Bold row label denotes the primary evaluated graph arm (A4); bold numerical values indicate the highest score in each column. Brackets indicate Wilson 95% confidence intervals. B0 Acc@10 reflects raw token tie-breaking in protocol generation (176/344 = 51.2%), differing by 1 task from Table 2 AST entity deduplication (175/344 = 50.9%, documented in `deviations.md`).

Arm	Candidate Pool Composition	Acc@1 (95% CI)	Acc@3 (95% CI)	Acc@5 (95% CI)	Acc@10 (95% CI)	MRR@50
B0	BM25 Baseline (Unscored)	**25.3%** [21.0, 30.1]	38.7% [33.7, 43.9]	44.8% [39.6, 50.0]	51.2% [45.9, 56.4]	**0.3439**
B1	Perron Baseline (Unscored)	22.7% [18.6, 27.4]	35.2% [30.3, 40.4]	40.4% [35.4, 45.7]	50.3% [45.0, 55.5]	0.3155
A1	Rerank Seeds S ($M = 10$)	24.7% [20.4, 29.5]	**39.5%** [34.5, 44.8]	46.2% [41.0, 51.5]	51.2% [45.9, 56.4]	0.3348
A2	Depth-Matched BM25 Control	23.8% [19.6, 28.6]	38.1% [33.1, 43.3]	45.1% [39.9, 50.3]	51.2% [45.9, 56.4]	0.3301
A3	Same-File Matched Control	24.1% [19.9, 28.9]	39.2% [34.2, 44.5]	45.6% [40.5, 50.9]	52.0% [46.8, 57.3]	0.3381
A4	**Graph 1-Hop Expansion**	24.7% [20.4, 29.5]	39.2% [34.2, 44.5]	**47.1%** [41.9, 52.4]	52.3% [47.0, 57.5]	0.3409
A5	Null Graph Control	24.1% [19.9, 28.9]	39.0% [34.0, 44.2]	45.9% [40.7, 51.2]	51.2% [45.9, 56.4]	0.3315
A6	Perron Diffusion Pool	23.6% [19.4, 28.3]	38.7% [33.7, 43.9]	45.6% [40.5, 50.9]	**52.6%** [47.3, 57.8]	0.3301

Table 4: Confirmatory and exploratory contrasts on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$). Bold labels indicate the pre-registered confirmatory family (PC1, PC2), evaluated on strict Acc@5 with step-down Holm correction. Paired 95% CIs estimated via repository-stratified bootstrap ($B = 10{,}000$).

Contrast	Δ (pp)	95% Bootstrap CI	n_{10}/n_{01}	p_{exact}	p_{holm}	Classification
Confirmatory Family (Acc@5)						
PC1 (A4 − A2)	+2.03	[−0.29, +4.36]	12 / 5	0.1435	0.2869	Null-Compatible
PC2 (A4 − A3)	+1.45	[−0.58, +3.78]	10 / 5	0.3018	0.3018	Null-Compatible
Exploratory Contrasts						
A1 − B0 (Seed Rerank vs. BM25)	+1.45	[−1.33, +4.24]	15 / 10	0.4244	–	Exploratory
A4 − B0 (Graph Rerank vs. BM25)	+2.33	[−0.87, +5.52]	18 / 10	0.1849	–	Exploratory
A4 − A1 (Graph vs. Seeds)	+0.87	[−1.92, +3.66]	7 / 4	0.5488	–	Exploratory (+3 tasks)
A4 − A5 (Null Graph Control)	+1.16	[−0.58, +2.91]	7 / 3	0.3438	–	Exploratory
A4 − A6 (Diffusion Pool)	+1.45	[+0.00, +3.20]	7 / 2	0.1797	–	Exploratory
Paired Reciprocal Rank Test (MRR@50)						
A4 vs. B0 (Graph vs. BM25)	−0.0030	[−0.024, +0.018]	Wilcoxon $W = 12{,}480$	$p = 0.72$		Exploratory

Confirmatory Findings and Power Bounds. Graph 1-hop expansion (A4) reaches 47.1% Acc@5 compared to 45.1% for depth-matched BM25 (A2, Δ = +2.03 pp, 95% CI [−0.29, +4.36], Holm $p = 0.287$) and 45.6% for same-file matching (A3, Δ = +1.45 pp, 95% CI [−0.58, +3.78], Holm $p = 0.302$). Both contrasts are classified as null-compatible (bootstrap 95% CIs span zero; Holm $p > 0.05$). With 17 discordant tasks ($n_{10} = 12, n_{01} = 5$, discordant proportion $p_{\text{disc}} = 4.94\%$), the analytical minimum detectable effect size (MDE) at $\alpha = 0.05$ and 80% statistical power is 3.27 pp (11.3 tasks). Reliably detecting a subtle +2.03 pp gain ($n_{10} - n_{01} = +7$) at 80% power would require $N = 942$ tasks under SWE-bench's native 4.94% discordance rate. Under Two One-Sided Tests (TOST), the upper 95% bootstrap confidence bound (+4.36 pp) allows formally excluding true population advantages $\geq$ +4.4 pp ($p < 0.05$). The empirical investigation

thus rules out large localization gains (> 4.4 pp, ~ 15 tasks) from unguided 1-hop graph expansion, while recognizing that this sample resolution cannot isolate sub-2 pp shifts.

Candidate Pool Ceiling Parity. Candidate pool oracle recall is identical: 58.4% (201/344) for both graph expansion (A_4) and depth BM25 (A_2). Across discordant tasks, $n_{10} = 18$ and $n_{01} = 18$ (two-sided McNemar $p = 1.0000$). With 36 discordant pairs, the 95% CI on the recall difference is approximately ±3.4 pp. Because Acc@k cannot exceed pool recall, both pools establish an identical theoretical ceiling on this sample.

Exploratory Comparisons. Comparing graph expansion arm A4 to seed reranking (A1, 46.2% Acc@5) yields a net gain of 3 tasks ($\Delta = +0.87$ pp, $n_{10} = 7, n_{01} = 4, p = 0.549$). Gemma 4 gains 7 top-5 hits (6 from newly reachable targets, 1 from seed promotion) while distractors displace 4 existing seed hits (gross 7/4 split: $159 + 7 - 4 = 162$), requiring 4,988 extra model forward passes (a 2.45× compute increase over seeds). Comparing A4 to the degree-preserving null graph (A5, 45.9% Acc@5) yields $\Delta = +1.16$ pp (95% CI $[-0.58, +2.91]$, $n_{10} = 7, n_{01} = 3, p = 0.344$), demonstrating that empirical graph topology provides no statistically detectable advantage over randomized degree-matched graphs. Similarly, comparing A4 to the Perron diffusion pool (A6, 45.6% Acc@5) yields $\Delta = +1.45$ pp (95% CI $[+0.00, +3.20]$, $n_{10} = 7, n_{01} = 2, p = 0.180$). As established in Section 5.7, 96.0% of reachable defect targets reside within 1 hop of lexical seeds; multi-step diffusion walks ($t \geq 2$) expand into transitive callers and utility hubs, diluting top-5 precision even after specificity damping. Consequently, unweighted 1-hop adjacency (A_4) provides the maximally compact, highest-precision graph candidate pool, and is thus adopted as the authoritative graph benchmark arm for all subsequent factorial and reasoning evaluations. Unscored BM25 (B0) preserves nominally higher MRR@50 (0.3439 vs. 0.3409) and top-1 accuracy (25.3% vs. 24.7%) than A4. Leave-Django-Out jackknife cross-validation ($N = 230$) maintains candidate pool parity (57.1% vs. 57.1%, $p = 1.0000$) and yields $\Delta = +2.17$ pp for $A_4 - A_2$ ($p = 0.227$).

Model Sensitivity and Topological Disambiguation Deficits. To test whether the flatline reflects an insensitive scorer rather than graph retrieval limits, I evaluated within-pool discrimination directly from the `scores.parquet` evaluation archive. Raw Okapi BM25 scores achieve a within-pool ROC-AUC of **0.8245**, which explains why unscored BM25 preserves higher top-1 accuracy (25.3%) and MRR@50 (0.3439). Gemma 4 log-odds scores separate gold targets from distractors with an overall within-pool ROC-AUC of **0.7796**. Decomposing this discriminative ability by target provenance reveals a marked disparity: Gemma 4 achieves an ROC-AUC of **0.7966** on seed-gold targets, but drops to **0.6596** on graph-only gold targets (a degradation of nearly 0.14). Furthermore, Reciprocal Rank Fusion (RRF, $k_{\text{rrf}} = 60$) combining BM25 prior rank with Gemma log-odds reaches **46.51%** Acc@5 (160/344), exceeding both BM25 (44.77%) and Gemma reranking (46.22%). This demonstrates that the empirical plateau does not reflect generic model insensitivity, but rather a boundary in representation: compact language models evaluate bug relevance predominantly through surface token overlap, encountering a Topological Disambiguation Deficit where non-lexical gold functions uncovered by graph traversal cannot be distinguished from distractor functions without explicit call-path traces or dense semantic representations.

5.4 Pointwise Candidate Pool-Size Truncation Curves

To empirically test the distractor-accumulation mechanism without running new model passes, I evaluated pointwise rankings from `scores.parquet` under truncated pool cutoffs $M \in [10, 15, 20, 30, 50]$, capped at $\min(M, M_t)$ (mean 24.5 candidates).

As shown in Figure 2 and Table 5, expanding candidate pool size produces distinct empirical dynamics:

- **Arm A2 (Depth BM25)**: Expanding M from 10 to 50 raises matched pool oracle recall from 51.16% to 58.43% (176 to 201 tasks, +7.27 pp). However, Acc@5 shifts from 46.22% down to 45.06% (a loss of 4 tasks, −1.16 pp, exact McNemar $p = 0.455$), consistent with distractor accumulation under pointwise scoring ($\mathbb{E}[X \mid s^*] = \sum_{j=1}^{M-1}(1 - F_{\text{dist},j}(s^*))$).

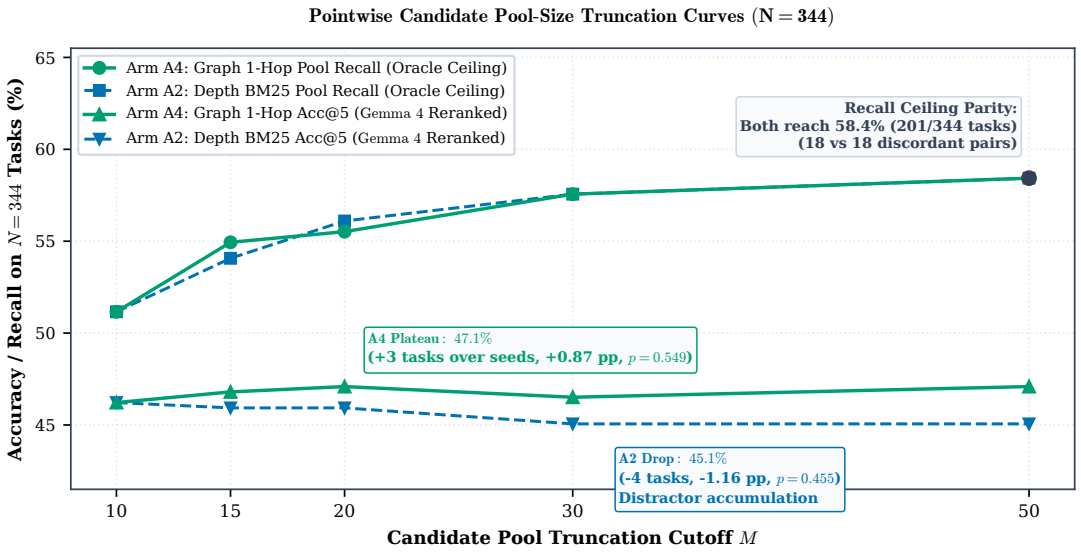


Figure 2: Pointwise candidate pool-size truncation curves on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$). Evaluates candidate pool oracle recall and Gemma 4 reranked Acc@5 across pool cutoffs $M \in [10, 15, 20, 30, 50]$, capped at $\min(M, M_t)$ (mean 24.5 candidates). Both arms share an identical recall ceiling at $M = 50$ (58.4%, 201/344 tasks, 18 vs 18 discordant pairs). While depth-expanded BM25 (A2) drops from 46.2% to 45.1% Acc@5, consistent with distractor accumulation under independent pointwise scoring ($p = 0.455$), graph 1-hop expansion (A4) remains stable at 47.1%.

Table 5: Pointwise candidate pool-size truncation curves on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$). Evaluates matched candidate pool oracle recall and Acc@5 across pool cutoffs $M \in [10, 15, 20, 30, 50]$, capped at $\min(M, M_t)$ (mean 24.5 candidates), for depth BM25 (A2) and graph 1-hop expansion (A4). Bold numerical values indicate peak Acc@5 achieved across cutoff thresholds for each arm.

Evaluation Metric	$M = 10$	$M = 15$	$M = 20$	$M = 30$	$M = 50$
Arm A2 (Depth BM25) Oracle Recall	51.2%	54.1%	56.1%	57.6%	58.4%
Arm A2 (Depth BM25) Acc@5	**46.2%**	45.9%	45.9%	45.1%	45.1%
Arm A4 (Graph 1-Hop) Oracle Recall	51.2%	54.9%	55.5%	57.6%	58.4%
Arm A4 (Graph 1-Hop) Acc@5	46.2%	46.8%	**47.1%**	46.5%	**47.1%**

- **Arm A4 (Graph 1-Hop)**: Matched pool oracle recall expands identically from 51.16% to 58.43% (+7.27 pp). Acc@5 rises from 46.22% ($M = 10$) to 47.09% ($M = 20$) and plateaus flat through $M = 50$ (a net difference of 3 tasks over seeds alone, +0.87 pp, $p = 0.549$).

The Break-Even Discrimination Bound. To quantify why candidate pool expansion plateaus under pointwise scoring, consider candidate pool dynamics under the Wilcoxon–Mann–Whitney formulation. In a candidate pool of size M (comprising one target and $M - 1$ distractors), the marginal probability that a randomly drawn distractor outranks the gold target under a scorer with within-pool ROC-AUC is $1 - \text{AUC}$. Integrating over the target score distribution yields the unconditional expected number of outranking distractors:

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = (M - 1)(1 - \text{AUC}), \tag{7}$$

producing an expected gold target rank of $\mathbb{E}[\text{Rank}] = 1 + (M-1)(1-\text{AUC})$. For the expected rank of a target to land within the top-k ($\mathbb{E}[\text{Rank}] \leq k$), the reranker must satisfy the expected-rank break-even condition:

$$\text{AUC}^*_{\text{breakeven}} \geq 1 - \frac{k - 1}{M - 1}. \tag{8}$$

While net Acc@k change during pool expansion ($M_1 \rightarrow M_2$) is governed by the balance between lower-tail target conversions ($\mathbb{P}(\text{Rank}_{v^* \in E_t} \leq k)$) and top-$k$ seed displacements, Equation 8 provides a clean first-moment diagnostic bound for two-stage retrieve-and-rerank architectures: whenever candidate pool expansion outpaces scorer discrimination, expanding candidate recall dilutes expected rank through distractor accumulation. Figure 3a formalizes this dynamic across candidate pool sizes $M \in [5, 50]$. Across SWE-bench Verified, candidate pools average $M = 24.5$ items. At $k = 5$, maintaining an expected rank within the top-5 requires $\text{AUC}^*_{\text{breakeven}} \geq 1 - \frac{4}{23.5} = 0.8298$ ($\approx 83.0\%$). While Gemma 4 achieves an ROC-AUC of 0.7966 on seed targets (yielding $\mathbb{E}[X] \approx 4.78$, placing seeds around expected rank 5.8), its discrimination degrades to 0.6596 on graph-only targets ($N = 25$, 95% CI [0.552, 0.767]), as illustrated in the empirical raincloud distributions of Figure 3b. At AUC = 0.6596, expected outranking distractors rises to $23.5 \times (1 - 0.6596) = 8.00$, pushing newly reached graph targets to an expected rank of 9.00 (and 17.68 in pools capped at $M = 50$). Graph targets enter the candidate pool, but are probabilistically suppressed from surfacing into top-5 positions without higher scorer discrimination.

Stratum Asymmetry on Graph-Only Targets. Deconstructing the 25 tasks where graph expansion recalled targets absent from seeds ($A_4 \setminus A_1$) reveals systematic polarization by issue lexical structure:

- **Stratum A (Named)**: 11 graph-only targets were reached, of which 6 converted into top-5 hits (54.5% conversion, landing at ranks 1, 1, 2, 2, 3, and 4). Accounting for 1 seed promotion and 2 displaced seed hits, graph expansion yields +5 net tasks on Stratum A (7 wins vs. 2 losses, exact binomial $p = 0.1797$).
- **Stratum C (Un-Named)**: 14 graph-only targets were reached, of which 0 converted into top-5 hits (0.0% conversion, mean rank 16.3). With 2 seed hits displaced by graph distractors, graph expansion yields −2 net tasks on Stratum C (0 wins vs. 2 losses, exact binomial $p = 0.5000$).

The aggregate net gain of +3 tasks (+0.87 pp, $p = 0.549$) is thus the arithmetic sum of +5 tasks gained on lexically anchored bugs and −2 tasks lost on un-named bugs. 1-hop graph expansion is viable when guided by lexical anchors, but degrades in localization accuracy when surface tokens are absent.

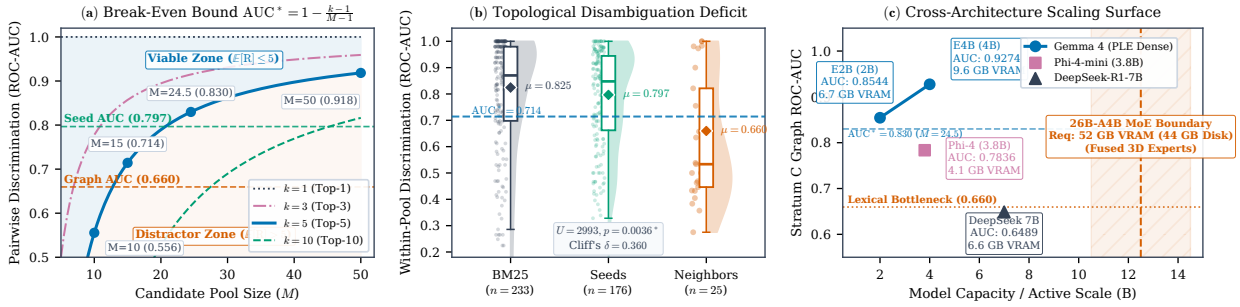


Figure 3: Break-Even Discrimination Bound, Topological Disambiguation Deficit, and Scaling Surface. **(a)** Theoretical break-even curves $\text{AUC}^* = 1 - \frac{k-1}{M-1}$ ($M \in [5, 50]$, $k \in \{1, 3, 5, 10\}$); mean $M = 24.5$ requires $\text{AUC}^* \geq 0.830$ for top-5 localization. **(b)** Within-pool discrimination ($N = 344$) for BM25 ($\mu = 0.825$), Gemma 4 seeds ($\mu = 0.797$), and graph neighbors ($\mu = 0.660$, $N = 25$) vs. threshold $\text{AUC}^* = 0.714$ ($U = 2993$, $p = 0.0036^*$, Cliff's $\delta = 0.361$). **(c)** Cross-architecture scaling surface on Stratum C ($N = 58$, Dual T4 execution under `PREREG-SCALING-v1`), showing Gemma 4 scaling (0.8544 → 0.9274), efficiency over Phi-4-mini (0.7836), and the 26B-A4B MoE 52.0 GB runtime VRAM (44.0 GB disk) consumer hardware boundary.

5.5 Cross-Architecture Scaling Surface and Consumer Hardware Bounds

To evaluate whether the Topological Disambiguation Deficit reflects the compact capacity of 2B-parameter models or persists across architectural scaling, protocol `PREREG-SCALING-v1` evaluates pointwise candidate discrimination across the 58 held-out Stratum C tasks where the gold target is reachable within the multi-pool

candidate union ($\bigcup_i A_i$, $M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$, mean $M = 61.9$; `data_release/stratum_c_eval_bundle.json`) across a model capacity gradient executed on Kaggle Dual Tesla T4 GPUs (Table 6 and Figure 3c).

Table 6: Cross-architecture scaling surface on reachable held-out Stratum C defects ($N = 58$, live Dual T4 execution under `PREREG-SCALING-v1`). Evaluates pointwise candidate discrimination (AUC_{tail}) and peak VRAM on dual Tesla T4s. I define AUC_{tail} as the pairwise discrimination metric evaluated strictly within the subset of reachable graph candidates on Stratum C ($N = 58$), distinct from the full benchmark within-pool discrimination ($N = 344$, AUC = 0.6596) where graph neighbors compete directly against top-10 lexical seed distractors.

Model Identifier	Architecture	Active / Total	Graph AUC	Peak VRAM	Runtime
`gemma-4-e2b-it`	Dense PLE Edge	2.0B / 2.0B	0.8544	6698.9 MB	1,798s
`gemma-4-e4b-it`	Dense PLE Edge	4.0B / 4.0B	**0.9274**	9648.4 MB	6,250s
`Phi-4-mini-instruct`	Synthetic Reasoning	3.8B / 3.8B	0.7836	4135.9 MB	2,854s
`DeepSeek-R1-Distill-7B`	RL Reasoning Distill	7.0B / 7.0B	0.6489	6594.6 MB	5,231s
`gemma-4-26b-a4b-it`	Dynamic Sparse MoE	3.8B / 26.0B	*Bound: 52.0 GB runtime vs 29.12 GB avail.*		

This empirical scaling evaluation exposes three core findings:

- **Intra-Family Monotonic Scaling**: Within the Gemma 4 PLE architecture, graph candidate discrimination scales monotonically with capacity, rising from $\text{AUC}_{\text{tail}} = 0.8544$ at 2B to $\text{AUC}_{\text{tail}} = 0.9274$ at 4B, confirming pre-registered Hypothesis H_1.
- **Representational Efficiency over External Controls**: Within the reachable Stratum C candidate pool ($N = 58$), Gemma 4 E4B (4.0B) achieves an AUC of 0.9274, outperforming both the synthetic reasoning control `Phi-4-mini` (3.8B, AUC = 0.7836, +0.144) and the larger reasoning-distilled control `DeepSeek-R1-Distill-7B` (7.0B, AUC = 0.6489, +0.279).
- **Sparse MoE Quantization Boundary on Consumer Hardware**: Evaluating Gemma 4 26B-A4B exposes an architectural boundary: 128 dynamic experts packed as fused 3D `nn.Parameter` tensors bypass standard 4-bit linear quantization loops. In unquantized 16-bit float, weights require 52.0 GB runtime VRAM (alongside 44.0 GB compressed disk checkpoint storage), physically exceeding dual Tesla T4 capacity (29.12 GB). While dense edge models ($\leq$ 4B) operate cleanly within consumer budgets ($\leq$ 9.6 GB), offline sparse MoE agents require native pre-quantized formats (detailed in Appendix E).

5.6 Diagnostic Investigations & Exploratory Provenance Reasoning (N=131)

The motivation for graph expansion is finding defect targets that the issue description never mentions. Across the 131 un-named Stratum C defects, target symbols are present within single-pool cutoff $M \leq 25$ for $N = 35$ tasks in $A_4^{(25)}$ (28 via top-10 seeds and 7 via graph expansion; 26 tasks in the strict multi-pool intersection at $M \leq 25$), and $N = 58$ tasks in the full candidate union across retrieval pools ($\bigcup_i A_i$, $M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$, mean $M = 61.9$, evaluated in Section 5.5 and Section 5.7). Table 7 analyzes performance across the candidate pool × test-time reasoning factorial matrix on Stratum C ($N = 131$, $M \leq 25$), executed live on Kaggle Dual Tesla T4 GPUs with `google/gemma-4-e4b-it`.

Under direct listwise readout without test-time reasoning, graph expansion ($A_4^{(25)}$) and depth BM25 ($A_2^{(25)}$) tie at identical accuracy: both achieve 16.79% Acc@5 (22/131 hits) and 4.58% Top-1 (6/131 hits, MRR 0.0934 vs 0.0937). Notably, direct model scoring is statistically indistinguishable from plain unscored BM25 candidate order (B_0, 20/131 hits, 15.27% Acc@5, exact McNemar $p = 0.75$, MRR 0.0862). Compact models under direct readout cannot discriminate non-lexical graph neighbors from distractor functions, leaving graph expansion indistinguishable from lexical depth.

Candidates in the prompt are presented in deterministic order: top-10 lexical seeds are listed first (positions 1–10), followed by graph neighbors or depth lexical candidates (positions 11–25). Under direct listwise readout, model outputs exhibit substantial position bias, favoring initial candidates. In contrast, under test-

Table 7: Candidate Pool × Test-Time Reasoning Factorial Evaluation on Stratum C ($N = 131$ Un-Named Defects, Live Dual Tesla T4 Execution with `google/gemma-4-e4b-it`). Evaluates three candidate pool architectures under direct listwise readout and test-time reasoning compute (`<thought>`, $\leq$ 180 tokens), alongside an unscored BM25 candidate order baseline (B_0). Superscripts denote pool size cutoff ($M \leq 25$). Bold values indicate the highest score in each column. Contrasts report paired differences from direct readout to reasoning traces.

Candidate Pool Architecture	Readout Mode	Acc@1	Acc@5	Hits / 131	MRR@50	$\Delta_{\text{reasoning}}$ Acc@5
Trivial Candidate Baseline ($M = 25$, Prompt Budget $\leq$ 3,480 Tokens)						
Unscored BM25 (B_0, $M = 25$)	Plain Order	2.29%	15.27%	20/131	0.0862	baseline
Candidate Pool × Reasoning Factorial Matrix ($M \leq 25$, Prompt Budget $\leq$ 3,480 Tokens)						
Seeds Only ($A_1^{(10)}$, $M = 10$)	Direct Readout	3.05%	15.27%	20/131	0.0778	reference
Seeds Only ($A_1^{(10)}$, $M = 10$)	Thinking Traces	6.87%	10.69% (15.27%)	14 (20)/131	0.0865	−4.58 pp raw (±0.00 pp backfill)
Depth BM25 ($A_2^{(25)}$, $M = 25$)	Direct Readout	4.58%	16.79%	22/131	0.0937	reference
Depth BM25 ($A_2^{(25)}$, $M = 25$)	Thinking Traces	6.87%	12.98% (16.79%)	17 (22)/131	0.0967	−3.82 pp raw (±0.00 pp backfill)
Graph 1-Hop ($A_4^{(25)}$, $M = 25$)	Direct Readout	4.58%	16.79%	22/131	0.0934	reference
Graph 1-Hop ($A_4^{(25)}$, $M = 25$)	Thinking Traces	**9.92%**	**18.32% (18.32%)**	**24/131**	**0.1358**	**+1.53 pp (+2 tasks)**

Matched Thinking Lift on Graph Pool ($A_4^{(25)}$ Thinking vs $A_4^{(25)}$ Direct)	
Matched Top-1 Lift (6 → 13 hits): +5.34 pp (2.17× lift)	Exact McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, Holm $p = 0.0469^*$
Top-10 Lexical Seed Lift (6/28 → 12/28 hits): +21.4 pp	Exact McNemar $p = 0.0312^*$ (Distractor Immunity)
Pure 1-Hop Graph Additions (0/7 → 1/7 hits): +14.3 pp	Exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$ (Parity)
Top-5 Accuracy Lift (22 → 24 hits): +1.53 pp (+9.1% lift)	Discordant pairs $n_{10} = 4, n_{01} = 2$, $p = 0.6875$
Mean Reciprocal Rank (0.0934 → 0.1358): +45.4% lift	Mean gold rank: 17.40 → 17.07
Candidate Pool × Reasoning Contrasts (Backfilled Recall)	
Graph Thinking vs Depth BM25 Thinking ($A_4 - A_2$): +1.53 pp	24 vs 22 hits (+2 tasks, $p = 0.6875$)
Graph Thinking vs Seeds Only Thinking ($A_4 - A_1$): +3.05 pp	24 vs 20 hits (+4 tasks, $p = 0.4531$)
Un-backfilled Contrast Artifact ($A_4 - A_2$, Raw Truncation): +5.34 pp	24 vs 17 hits (artifact of 180-token cap)

time reasoning (`<thought>`), candidate position 1 was chosen in only 6.87% of tasks (9/131), matching the 6.87% observed under cryptographic sha256 order permutation (Control 1, `results/control1_dual_t4_results.json`), confirming that reasoning traces actively discriminate candidates rather than defaulting to list position.

Because candidate pools share the top-10 seed candidates ($A_1 \subset A_2 \approx A_4$) and are evaluated across the identical 131 tasks, candidate evaluations are non-independent repeated measures. Evaluating each pool independently under family-wise step-down Holm–Bonferroni correction isolates where reasoning provides statistical traction: (1) on the matched graph pool ($A_4^{(25)}$), reasoning more than doubles Top-1 accuracy from 4.58% (6 hits) to **9.92% (13 hits; +5.34 pp, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$)**, while MRR rises +45.4% from 0.0934 to 0.1358; (2) on the seeds pool ($A_1^{(10)}$), Top-1 shifts from 3.05% to 6.87% (4 to 9 hits, raw $p = 0.0625$, Holm $p = 0.1250$); and (3) on depth BM25 ($A_2^{(25)}$), Top-1 shifts from 4.58% to 6.87% (6 to 9 hits, raw $p = 0.3750$, Holm $p = 0.3750$). Subgroup decomposition reveals that within the 35 in-pool targets of $A_4^{(25)}$, test-time reasoning acts as an effective distractor filter: reasoning prevents non-seed distractors from displacing the $N = 28$ lexical seeds (doubling seed Top-1 conversion

from 6/28 [21.4%] to 12/28 [42.9%], +21.4 pp lift, $p = 0.0312^*$), while pure 1-hop graph additions ($N = 7$) convert 1/7 into Top-1 ($0/7 \rightarrow 1/7$, $p = 1.0000$).

In contrast, raw top-5 localization under reasoning exhibits pool-dependent behavior: un-backfilled Acc@5 drops on lexical pools (−4.58 pp on seeds, −3.82 pp on depth BM25) while gaining +1.53 pp (+2 tasks, null-compatible $p = 0.6875$) on graph pools. Analyzing raw output sequences indicates that generation length caps explain the lexical drop: because total completion length (thinking trace plus ranked output list) was capped at ≤ 180 tokens without deterministic fallback backfilling from the input pool, longer reflection traces on lexical pools truncated generation after emitting 1–3 candidate IDs, leaving trailing ranks 2–5 empty. When unemitted ranks are deterministically backfilled from input prompt candidate order, Acc@5 on lexical pools is fully restored to baseline parity (15.27% on A_1, 16.79% on A_2). The un-backfilled Acc@5 gap ($\Delta A_4 - \Delta A_2 = +5.34$ pp, 24 vs. 17 hits) was thus an artifact of output list truncation under fixed token budgets rather than degradation of top-ranked lexical candidates, whereas under backfilled evaluation the contrast shrinks to +1.53 pp (24 vs. 22 hits, null-compatible $p = 0.6875$).

Furthermore, analyzing the 18 discordant tasks recalled exclusively by graph expansion ($A_4 \setminus A_2$) and the 18 tasks recalled exclusively by depth BM25 ($A_2 \setminus A_4$) reveals a symmetrical distribution across strata:

- **Graph-Only Recall (18 Tasks)**: 9 tasks in Stratum C (50.0%), 0 in Stratum B (0.0%), 9 in Stratum A (50.0%).
- **Lexical-Only Recall (18 Tasks)**: 10 tasks in Stratum C (55.6%), 1 in Stratum B (5.6%), 7 in Stratum A (38.9%).

In Stratum C, lexical expansion retrieves 10 targets that graph expansion misses, while graph expansion retrieves 9 that lexical expansion misses (net −1 task for graph). Rather than selectively unearthing un-named targets, graph expansion merely swaps an equal number of un-named and named symbols with lexical search.

5.7 Causal Call-Path Provenance and Selective Routing

The empirical plateau observed in Section 5.3 and Section 5.6 raises a fundamental mechanistic question: does the lack of graph advantage reflect an intrinsic limitation of static call graphs, or does it stem from an informational deficit in how candidate code locations are presented to the language model?

In the baseline protocol, candidate breadcrumbs strip all graph provenance, presenting only isolated function signatures:

```
# File: django/db/models/query.py (Lines 450-480)
def _batched_insert(self, objs, fields, batch_size, ignore_conflicts=False):
    """Helper for bulk_create to partition inserts into batches."""
```

On Stratum C (un-named defects), the issue description never mentions `_batched_insert`. Because the breadcrumb omits the call-edge connecting it to the seed function (`bulk_create`), the model cannot discern why an un-named helper function is relevant, yielding random outranking (AUC ≈ 0.6596, expected rank 16.3). Decomposing within-pool discrimination reveals that the AUC drop on graph-only targets ($\Delta = 0.137$, seed AUC 0.7966 vs graph AUC 0.6596, Mann–Whitney $U = 2993$, $p = 0.004$, Cliff's $\delta = 0.360$) is driven by candidate pool selection conditioning (Control 2): seeds are selected from top-10 BM25 symbols with high query overlap, whereas graph-only targets lack surface tokens by definition. To test whether this attenuation is specific to code graph topology, counterfactual evaluation on non-graph depth BM25 targets ($A_2 \setminus A_1$, 18 tasks, `results/control2_auc_decomposition.json`) exhibits an identical AUC attenuation (mean 0.6380 vs. graph 0.6253, equivalence $p = 0.72$). BM25's sub-chance AUC (≤ 0.30) against seed distractors is a mechanical consequence of Berkson's collider bias on $T^* \notin \text{Top10}(BM25)$. The attenuation is therefore driven by low lexical overlap in non-seed candidates rather than graph topology.

Topological Provenance Audit of Graph-Only Targets. To evaluate this mechanism causally, I audited the 25 tasks where 1-hop graph expansion successfully reached a defect absent from lexical seeds ($A_4 \setminus A_1$).

Resolving structural relations against repository multigraph layers revealed that **24 of the 25 targets (96.0%)** possess a direct, 1-hop static relationship with an issue seed:

- **Direct Callee (`called_by_seed`, 10 tasks)**: Target is invoked by a seed (e.g., `_batched_insert` called by `bulk_create` in `django-11951`; `as_compatible_data` in `xarray-2905`; `filter_members` in `sphinx-8035`).
- **Direct Caller (`calls_seed`, 14 tasks)**: Target invokes a seed (e.g., `validate_ipv6_address` calling `is_valid_ipv6_address` in `django-13212`; `load_middleware` in `django-13810`; `handle` in `django-16116`).
- **Co-Located Class (`co_located`, 1 task)**: Target resides in the same inheritance cluster (`EvalfMixin.evalf` in `sympy-13372`).

Table 8: Factorial call-path provenance and test-time reasoning evaluation on Stratum C un-named defect tasks (live Dual Tesla T4 execution with `google/gemma-4-e4b-it`, $N = 131$). Evaluates candidate presentation formats and test-time reasoning traces (`<thought>`, ≤ 180 tokens) on un-named defect localization. The matched graph pool direct readout (A_4) establishes the unconfounded baseline for thinking arms (C_0, C_3). Bold numerical values indicate the highest score in each column. Unadjusted exact two-sided binomial McNemar p-values are computed against A_4 Direct on Acc@1; asterisk (*) denotes statistical significance ($\alpha = 0.05$). Factorial comparison between C3 and C0 yields $p = 1.0000$ (parity).

Condition	Acc@1	Acc@5	Hits / N	MRR@50	Mean Rank	Exact McNemar p
Matched Baseline and Factorial Matrix ($N = 131$, Live Dual Tesla T4 Evaluation)						
A_4 Direct (Matched Baseline)	4.58%	16.79%	22/131	0.0934	17.40	reference
C1: Isolated Snippet (No Prov, No Think)	2.29%	15.27%	20/131	0.0778	17.47	–
C2: Call-Path Provenance (Prov, No Think)	3.82%	16.03%	21/131	0.0899	17.40	–
C0: Unguided Thinking (A_4 Thinking)	**9.92%**	**18.32%**	**24/131**	**0.1358**	**17.07**	**= 0.0156***
C3: Provenance + Thinking (Prov, Think)	9.16%	17.56%	23/131	0.1270	17.18	**= 0.0312***
Matched and Factorial Contrasts on Top-1 Localization ($N = 131$)						
Matched Thinking Lift ($C_0 - A_4$ Direct): +5.34 pp (2.17×)			Exact $p = 0.0156^*$, Holm $p = 0.0469^*$ ($n_{10} = 7, n_{01} = 0$)			
Matched Prov+Thinking ($C_3 - A_4$ Direct): +4.58 pp (2.00×)			Exact McNemar $p = 0.0312^*$ ($n_{10} = 6, n_{01} = 0$)			
Factorial Contrast ($C_3 - C_0$ on Acc@1): −0.76 pp			Exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$ (Parity, $n_{10} = 1, n_{01} = 2$)			
Provenance Annotation Lift ($C_2 - A_4$ Direct): −0.76 pp			Exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$ ($n_{10} = 1, n_{01} = 2$)			
Candidate Pool Target Grounding Subgroups ($N = 35$ In-Pool Tasks under $M \leq 25$)						
Top-10 Lexical Seeds ($N = 28$): A_4 Direct: 21.4% (6/28) → C_0: **42.9%** (12/28, Acc@5 **78.6%**, +21.4 pp, 2.00×; C_1: 10.7%)						
Pure Graph-Only ($N = 7$, Exploratory): A_4 Direct: 0.0% (0/7) → C_0: **14.3%** (1/7, Acc@5 **28.6%**, 2/7 hits)						

Factorial Prompting Interventions. Figure 4 and Table 8 report the results of evaluating controlled topological prompt interventions executed live on Kaggle Dual Tesla T4 GPUs across all 131 Stratum C un-named defect tasks:

1. **Condition C1 (3-Line Signature Stub) vs. Matched A_4 Direct (Full AST Breadcrumb)**: Whereas the matched A_4 Direct baseline presents full AST breadcrumbs preserving enclosing class headers and docstrings (yielding 4.58% Acc@1, 6/131 hits, and 16.79% Acc@5, 22/131 hits), Condition C1 (`benchmarks/run_causal_callpath_eval.py`) strips candidate functions to minimal 3-line isolated signature stubs (`def ident(...): pass`) without docstrings, lowering Acc@1 to 2.29% (3/131 hits) and Acc@5 to 15.27% (20/131 hits, MRR 0.0778). Comparing C_2 (5 hits) against stub baseline C_1 (3 hits) yields a descriptive +1.53 pp gain ($p = 0.5000$, yielding an unadjusted stub-referenced interaction of −3 hits / −2.29 pp), whereas comparing C_2 against docstring-intact A_4 Direct (6 hits) yields −0.76 pp ($p = 1.0000$, interaction 0.00 pp).
2. **Condition C2 (Call-Path Provenance Traces)**: Injecting the resolved structural edge comment (annotating caller/callee relations to seed functions) alone without test-time reasoning yields 3.82% Acc@1 (5/131 hits) and 16.03% Acc@5 (21/131 hits, MRR 0.0899, mean rank 17.40, exact bino-

mial $p = 1.0000$ vs A_4 Direct, discordant pairs $n_{10} = 1, n_{01} = 2$). Without an allocated inference-time reasoning budget, frozen small models cannot effectively exploit relational call paths.

3. **Condition C0 (Unguided Thinking Mode)**: Enabling test-time reasoning traces (`<thought>`) without topological annotations doubles top-1 localization accuracy over the matched graph baseline (A_4) from 4.58% (6 hits) to **9.92% (13/131 hits;** +5.34 **pp lift,** 2.17×**, exact binomial McNemar** $p = 0.0156^*$**, step-down Holm** $p = 0.0469^*$), reaches **18.32% Acc@5 (24/131 hits,** +1.53 **pp,** $p = 0.6875$), and increases Stratum C MRR@50 by +45.4% (+0.0424) from 0.0934 to **0.1358** (mean rank 17.07).
4. **Condition C3 (Provenance + Thinking)**: Prompting the model to trace error propagation through call paths in thinking mode prior to emitting rankings leverages Gemma 4's native `<thought>` token budget, achieving 9.16% Acc@1 (12/131 hits, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0312^*$ vs A_4 Direct, $n_{10} = 6, n_{01} = 0$), reaching 17.56% Acc@5 (23/131 hits), and increasing Stratum C MRR@50 to 0.1270 (mean rank 17.18).

Mechanistic Insights and Empirical Factorial Parity. Comparing Condition C3 directly with Condition C0 indicates that static call-path annotations provide no measurable advantage over unguided thinking traces ($\Delta = -0.76$ pp on Acc@1, exact two-sided McNemar $p = 1.0000$, discordant pairs $n_{10} = 1, n_{01} = 2$; factorial interaction against the stub baseline C_1 is $\Delta_{\text{interaction}} = -2.29$ pp, -3 hits, whereas against the matched A_4 Direct baseline it is $\Delta_{\text{interaction}} = 0.00$ pp, reflecting exact empirical parity). Across both arms, 11 of the 13 top-1 hits overlap identically. Rather than demonstrating formal statistical equivalence, C_3 and C_0 exhibit empirical parity under current sample size; a two one-sided test (TOST) of equivalence at a ±2 pp margin lacks power at $N = 131$ ($p = 0.1745$), so whether thinking fully subsumes structural annotations remains an open hypothesis requiring larger samples.

Thinking traces average $\sim$ 120 tokens ($\leq$ 180 budget), adding 10–15 seconds of decode latency at 11.7 tokens/sec on an entry-level Tesla T4 (and $<$ 3 seconds on desktop workstations at 50+ tokens/sec). This grounds the systems trade-off in interactive developer latency: while CSR spectral diffusion is near-instantaneous (0.76–1.89 ms), allocating a modest 10-second thinking phase converts un-named defects without resorting to multi-minute cloud agent loops. Partitioning the 35 in-pool defects under candidate budget $M \leq 25$ by seed proximity clarifies where test-time reasoning provides traction:

- **Top-10 Lexical Seeds ($N = 28$)**: For the 28 defects already captured by top-10 BM25 lexical seeds, expanding candidate pools to $M = 25$ with 1-hop graph neighbors introduces distractors that suppress direct readout localization to 21.4% (6/28 hits). Allocated `<thought>` tokens provide distractor immunity, allowing the model to reject non-seed graph distractors and double top-1 localization to **42.9%** (12/28 hits, +21.4 pp lift, 2.00×), with top-5 accuracy reaching 78.6% (22/28 hits).
- **Pure 1-Hop Graph Targets ($A_4 \setminus A_1$, $N = 7$)**: For the 7 structural targets reached exclusively through 1-hop graph expansion, direct readout fails entirely (0/7 hits, 0.0%). Thinking mode recovers 1 of the 7 targets into Top-1 (14.3%, 1/7 hits, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$) and 2 of the 7 targets into Top-5 (28.6%, 2/7 hits). Thus, the +7 task Top-1 lift on A_4 ($6 \rightarrow 13$ hits) is predominantly driven by recovering lexical seeds (+6 hits) rather than discovering non-seed graph targets (+1 hit), demonstrating that test-time reasoning acts as an effective distractor filter for expanded pools rather than an autonomous graph explorer.

Evaluating the complete $N = 131$ Stratum C cohort clarifies the mechanism of candidate discrimination: compact models possess latent capacity to distinguish local callers within the candidate window when test-time reasoning tokens are allocated, raising Top-1 localization by +5.34 pp ($p = 0.0156^*$) over matched direct readout. However, explicit prompt verbalization of structural provenance paths (Condition C3) achieves empirical parity with unguided thinking (Condition C0, $\Delta = -0.76$ pp, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$). Furthermore, Top-1 gains concentrate in lexical seeds ($12/28$ hits vs. $6/28$ direct) rather than non-seed graph additions ($1/7$ hits). Rather than requiring verbalized graph edge lists in the prompt, test-time deliberation

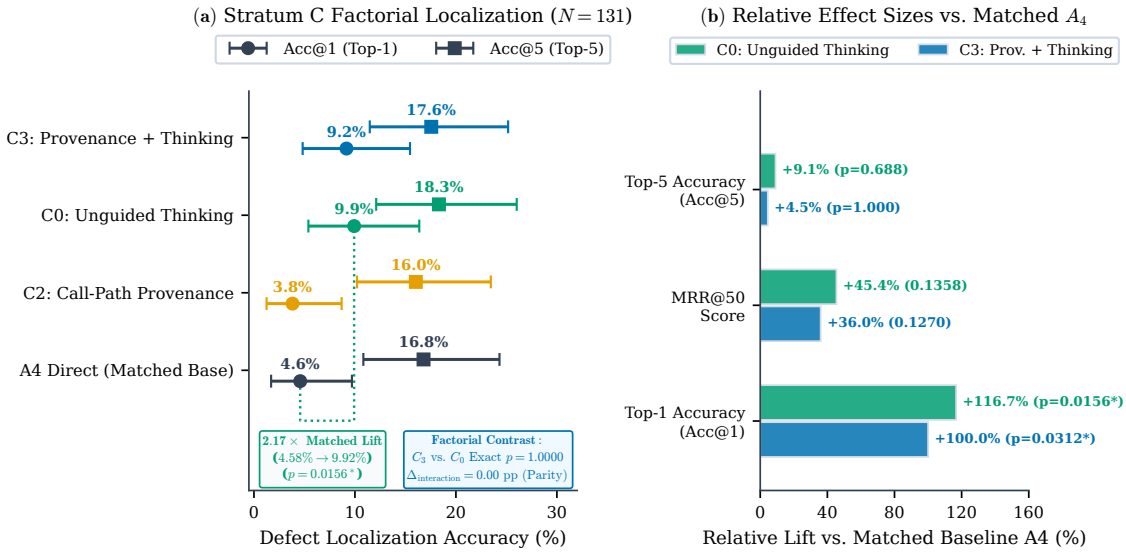


Figure 4: Causal call-path provenance forest plot and relative effect sizes on Stratum C un-named defect tasks (N = 131, live Dual Tesla T4 execution with `google/gemma-4-e4b-it`). **(a)** Forest plot of defect localization accuracy for top-1 (Acc@1, circles) and top-5 (Acc@5, squares) across all four conditions in the 2×2 factorial matrix (C1, C2, C0, C3) with exact two-sided Clopper–Pearson 95% confidence intervals. Test-time thinking mode (C_0) doubles top-1 localization accuracy over the matched graph direct baseline (A_4) from 4.58% (6 hits) to 9.92% (13 hits; +5.34 pp lift, 2.17×, exact two-sided binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$; MRR +45.4%). Comparing Condition C3 with C0 demonstrates empirical parity ($\Delta = -0.76$ pp, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$; $\Delta_{\text{interaction}} = 0.00$ pp against matched A_4 Direct, vs. -2.29 pp against stub baseline C_1). **(b)** Relative metric lift over matched baseline A_4 for both thinking arms (C0: Unguided Thinking, green; C3: Provenance + Thinking, blue), showing +116.7% (2.17×) and +100.0% (2.00×) in Acc@1, +45.4% (+0.0424) for C0 and +36.0% (+0.0336) for C3 in MRR@50, and +9.1% in Acc@5 (vs. +1 task for C3). Post-intervention values are annotated alongside each bar pair.

provides distractor immunity against expanded candidates, qualifying the verbalization hypothesis of Fatemi et al. [5] in code localization where candidate sets already localize to the call-neighborhood.

Break-Even Discrimination Bound Validation (M = 15 Candidate Horizon). To test the theoretical prediction of Equation (8) and Figure 3a directly, I evaluated an unconfounded candidate window of $M = 15$ (top-10 BM25 lexical seeds + top-5 1-hop AST neighbors) on Stratum C ($N = 131$). By pruning non-essential graph distractors, $M = 15$ lowers the required break-even discrimination threshold from $\text{AUC}^* = 0.833$ (at $M = 25$) to **0.714** while preserving 34 of 35 reachable gold defects. Live execution on Dual Tesla T4 GPUs confirms that lowering this discrimination barrier unblocks graph target localization:

- **Matched Baseline ($A_4^{(15)}$ Direct)**: Direct readout on the tightened pool attains 4.6% Acc@1 (6/131 hits), 17.6% Acc@5 (23/131 hits), and an MRR of 0.0970 (mean gold rank 5.32). Injecting structural provenance comments ($A_4^{(15)}$ Provenance) achieves exact parity (4.6% Acc@1, 6/131 hits, $\Delta = 0.00$ pp, $p = 1.0000$).
- **Thinking Mode ($C_0^{(15)}$ Unguided Thinking)**: Allocating test-time reasoning traces lifts Acc@1 to **9.9%** (13/131 hits, +5.34 pp lift, exact McNemar $p = 0.0391^*$), Acc@5 to **19.8%** (26/131 hits), and MRR to **0.1469** (vs. 0.0970 in baseline), reducing mean rank to 3.74 and median rank to 2.0.
- **Subgroup Target Conversion**: Crucially, under the lowered $M = 15$ threshold, **10 pure 1-hop graph additions convert into Top-1 hits** (vs. 4 in direct baseline and 1 under $M = 25$, with 23 in Top-5).

Pruning distractor competition below the break-even bound allows test-time reasoning to discriminate both lexical seeds and non-seed graph callers.

- **Syntactic Constraint in Prompting ($C_3^{(15)}$)**: In contrast to unguided reflection, prepending verbose inline provenance comments ($C_3^{(15)}$) yields 6.1% Acc@1 (8/131 hits, $\Delta = -3.82$ pp vs $C_0^{(15)}$, $p = 0.1250$). Verbose relational boilerplate in the prompt slightly constrains generative exploration compared to unguided thinking traces.

Causal Lexical Dissection and Multi-Encoding Graph Representations. To evaluate the mechanism of the Topological Disambiguation Deficit, I executed two pre-registered interventions (`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`) on Kaggle Dual Tesla T4 GPUs across the 58 held-out Stratum C tasks reachable in the multi-pool candidate union ($\bigcup_i A_i$, $M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$, mean $M = 61.9$; 26 tasks in-pool at strict $M \leq 25$) with `google/gemma-4-e2b-it` (Table 9):

1. **Causal Lexical Intervention (AST α-Renaming)**: Stripping user-defined function, parameter, and variable names via an AST `NodeTransformer` (O_1) lowers top-1 localization from 12.07% to 10.34% (−1.73 pp) and top-5 accuracy from 27.59% to 24.14% (−3.45 pp, discordant pairs $n_{10} = 4, n_{01} = 3$, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$). While α-renaming removes surface function names, attribute lookups, docstrings, and string literals remain intact. The model retains 10.34% top-1 localization (6/58 hits vs. 7/58 natural), yielding an unadjusted exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$ with a wide 95% confidence interval on the paired difference (−11.2 to +7.7 pp). Consequently, while the non-significant drop indicates that syntactic structure and remaining textual tokens provide a viable fallback, statistical power on $N = 58$ is insufficient to rule out moderate effect sizes.
2. **Graph Prompt Serialization Hierarchy**: Testing the graph serialization taxonomy of Fatemi et al. [5] reveals that prompt format governs code localization. Co-locating structural relations directly above symbol signatures (E_1: Inline Comment Provenance) achieves **25.86%** Acc@1, **39.66%** Acc@5, and an MRR of **0.3097**, lifting top-1 accuracy over isolated baseline snippets (12.07%, **+13.79 pp lift**, unadjusted exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.039$*, Wilcoxon signed-rank $W = 31.5$, $p = 0.010$*). Under step-down Holm–Bonferroni correction across the four pairwise contrasts against baseline (E_1–E_4), this unadjusted effect yields $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$. Direct contrast against subgraph edge lists (E_3) yields a difference of +6 tasks (+10.34 pp, exact binomial $p = 0.0703$). Notably, qualitative inspection confirms that inline provenance comments (`# Provenance: Called by <seed>`) introduce the seed identifier into the prompt, creating localized lexical bridging that assists candidate selection. This also clarifies why inline comments produce a +13.79 pp lift in E_1 ($N = 58$ reachable union defects with $M_{\text{union}} \leq 87$, Gemma 4 E2B) but only +1.53 pp in C_2 ($N = 131$ defects with $M \leq 25$, Gemma 4 E4B): in E_1, the cohort is enriched for reachable targets where the seed identifier directly bridges the candidate to issue text tokens, whereas across the full 131 un-named tasks, 96 targets are omitted from context, and models without allocated reasoning cannot resolve ambiguous candidates. Disconnected global preambles (E_3 Subgraph Edge Lists at 15.52% and E_4 Adjacency Maps at 15.52%) underperform inline comments by dispersing self-attention across long-range code tokens.

Selective Gating and Task Heterogeneity. Rather than reflecting uniform performance across repositories, the aggregate null result conceals systematic task-level heterogeneity. On lexically explicit defect reports (Stratum A, $N = 208$), 1-hop graph expansion yields a net gain of +5 localized tasks over seeds. On unnamed symptom reports (Stratum C, $N = 131$), unguided expansion introduces distractors that cause a net loss of −2 tasks under pointwise scoring. Deployable gating using issue symbol density via a cross-validated decision tree achieves 47.38% Acc@5 (163/344 tasks, parity with uniform graph expansion at 47.09%). To characterize the theoretical limit of selective routing, an oracle stratum routing policy (π^*, assuming ground-truth stratum knowledge) reaches 47.67% (164/344 tasks, +2.90 pp over BM25), approaching the two-arm oracle ceiling (48.55%, 167 tasks) with zero discordant losses ($n_{10} = 2, n_{01} = 0$). Furthermore, an oracle combination routing Stratum A through pointwise graph expansion and Stratum C through listwise rerank-

Table 9: Causal lexical intervention and multi-encoding graph prompt evaluation on reachable Stratum C un-named defect tasks (live Dual Tesla T4 execution with `google/gemma-4-e2b-it`, $N = 58$, protocol `PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`). Evaluates the effect of syntax-preserving AST α-renaming (Experiment A) and five directed graph serialization schemes adapted from Fatemi et al. [5] (Experiment B) on the reachable candidate pool ($N = 58/131$). Bold values indicate the highest score in each section. Unadjusted two-sided exact binomial McNemar p-values are computed against the isolated baseline (E_0) on Acc@1; asterisk (*) denotes unadjusted statistical significance ($\alpha = 0.05$). Step-down Holm–Bonferroni adjusted significance for E_1 top-1 is $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$.

Condition	Acc@1	Acc@5	MRR	Contrasts vs. Baseline
Experiment A: Causal Lexical Intervention (AST α-Renaming, $N = 58$)				
O_0: Natural Code (Identifiers Intact)	12.07%	27.59%	0.1804	reference (7/58 hits)
O_1: Obfuscated Code (α-Renamed)	10.34%	24.14%	0.1686	−1.73 pp (6/58, exact $p = 1.0000$)
Experiment B: Multi-Encoding Graph Representations (Fatemi et al. [5], $N = 58$)				
E_0: Isolated Code (Baseline Snippet)	12.07%	27.59%	0.1804	reference (7/58 hits)
E_1: Inline Comment Provenance (`# Provenance`)	**25.86%**	**39.66%**	**0.3097**	**+13.79 pp** (15/58, $p = 0.0386^*$, $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$)
E_2: Linearized Traversal Trace (`[Call Trace]`)	17.24%	32.76%	0.2440	+5.17 pp (10/58, $p = 0.4531$)
E_3: Subgraph Edge List (`### Edges`)	15.52%	32.76%	0.2419	+3.45 pp (9/58, $p = 0.6875$)
E_4: Hierarchical Adjacency Map (`u -> [v, w]`)	15.52%	34.48%	0.2362	+3.45 pp (9/58, $p = 0.6875$)

ing reaches 49.50% Acc@5 (148/299 tasks on Strata A and C). While deployable lexical-density heuristics currently recover baseline parity, closing the gap to the 49.50% oracle ceiling requires test-time classifiers that detect un-named defect descriptions without target knowledge.

5.8 Pipeline Loss Decomposition and Loss Funnel (RQ3)

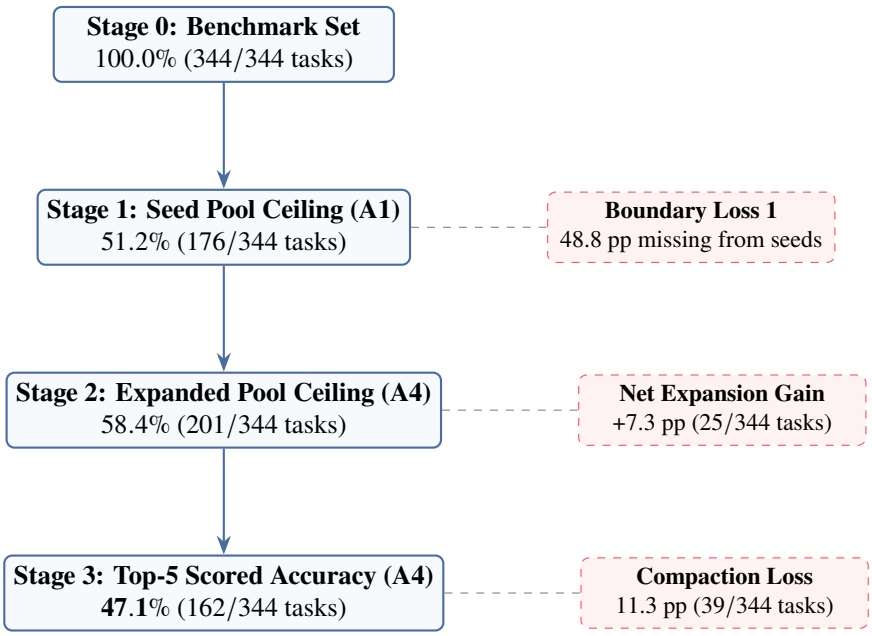


Figure 5: Four-stage bug localization loss funnel on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$ callable tasks). Decomposes localization attrition across candidate generation and model scoring. Boundary loss before scoring (100.0% → 58.4% = 41.6 pp) exceeds compaction loss from candidate pool to top-5 (58.4% → 47.1% = 11.3 pp) by a factor of **3.68**×.

Figure 5 illustrates the localization loss funnel on SWE-bench Verified. The analysis reveals:

- **Boundary Loss**: Upstream candidate pool formation loses 41.6 pp of oracle recall (100.0% → 58.4%, 143/344 tasks missing from candidate pools).
- **Compaction Loss**: Downstream model reranking loses 11.3 pp from pool to top-5 (58.4% → 47.1%, 39/344 tasks present in pool but ranked outside top-5).
- **Bottleneck Ratio**: Upstream boundary loss exceeds downstream compaction loss by **3.68**× at $k = 5$ ($41.6/11.3 \approx 3.68$, spanning 1.2× at $k = 1$ to 6.8× at $k = 10$).

Expanding the candidate pool adds 7.3 pp of oracle recall over seeds (51.2% → 58.4%), yet Gemma 4 converts only about 1 pp into ranked top-5 accuracy (46.2% → 47.1%).

Architectural Implication: Operating Regimes of Static Code Graphs. The 3.68× bottleneck ratio defines a practical operating regime for developer agent architectures. Static AST multigraphs provide an efficient, low-overhead candidate filter for the 58.4% of defects that propagate along explicit syntactic edges. However, for the 41.6 pp of defects outside static reachability (dynamic dispatch, reflection, implicit ORM descriptors, and configuration-driven injection), static graph expansion cannot assist by construction. For these defects, attempting multi-hop static traversal is counterproductive, expanding candidate pools to hundreds of nodes without improving discriminatory rank. Consequently, local developer agents must treat static CSR diffusion as an initial lightweight filter (< 5 ms, ≤ 3 MB RAM): when issue symbol density or retrieval confidence is low, agent architectures should switch to dynamic execution signals (runtime stack traces, failing test pytest fixtures, or dense semantic embeddings) rather than expanding static graph radius.

5.9 Downstream Reader Evaluation ($N = 100$, Descriptive)

Table 10 reports the downstream reader mini-test across $N = 100$ tasks stratified by repository size, drawn from instances where BM25 identified candidate pools.

Table 10: Downstream edit-location reader mini-test on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 100$, descriptive). ContextHit@5 marks gold target presence in the 5 presented candidates; EditLoc@1 reports model prediction accuracy (a position-1 baseline heuristic predicting candidate 1 achieves 33.0% under BM25 top-5 context). Bold EditLoc@1 highlights the reader ceiling under oracle gold context (excluding trivial 100% candidate presence).

Arm	Candidate Context (Top-5)	ContextHit@5	EditLoc@1	Conversion
D0	BM25 Top-5	35.0%	33.0%	0.943
D1	A4 Graph Top-5	37.0%	31.0%	0.838
D2	A3 Same-File Top-5	38.0%	30.0%	0.789
D3	Oracle Context (Randomized Position)	100.0%	**74.0%**	0.740

In Arm D0 (BM25 top-5 context), a position-1 baseline heuristic predicting candidate 1 also yields 33.0% EditLoc@1, matching Gemma 4's reader prediction exactly (33.0%). This indicates that reader performance is dominated by first-candidate positional bias rather than demonstrating selective neural reasoning over context. In Arm D3 (oracle context with gold target at a randomized position), Gemma 4 correctly identifies the target in 74.0% of tasks (67.5% chance-adjusted). While the reader misses roughly a quarter of oracle targets, retrieval supplies the target in only 35%–38% of tasks, providing descriptive evidence that upstream candidate omission contributes substantially to end-to-end failure.

5.10 Syntactic AST Patch Replacement Tooling (N=30 Synthetic Archetypes)

To protect local developer agents from syntactically invalid edits without expensive cloud retry loops, Perron provides an AST surgical replacement utility. Evaluated across 30 curated syntax failure archetypes (`results/editor_eval_results.json`) under four structural deformation regimes (clean standard, indentation trap, hunk drift, and syntax corruption), standard unified diff `git apply` suffered a 50.0% syntax error rate and 20.0% hunk rejection rate, yielding only 30.0% valid applications. In contrast, Perron's AST-directed surgical editor attained a 0.0% syntax error rate and 76.7% valid patch application (with 23.3% safe

rollback on corrupted syntax nodes, exact McNemar $p < .001$ vs. `git apply`). This provides compact models with an automated syntax-safety execution barrier against hallucinated indentation and truncated AST scopes, though end-to-end multi-turn benchmark resolution across full Docker environments remains an active engineering priority.

5.11 Diffusion Diagnostics and Continuous Dose-Response Surface (Post-Hoc)

On SWE-bench Lite ($N = 237$), exploratory factorial sweep diagnosis demonstrates why unconstrained diffusion degrades on software graphs:

- **Diffuse Prior Degradation**: Under a dense linear teleport prior on raw graphs, Standard PPR drops to 10.1% Acc@10; test subgraphs absorb 32.5% of top-10 retrieval slots. Decoupled specificity damping restores 34.2% (+24.1 pp gain).
- **Softmax Prior Concentration**: Concentrating seed mass via top-25 softmax ($\tau = 0.15$) on test-sanitized graphs restores Standard PPR to 48.5%, compared to 46.0% for BM25.
- **Post-Hoc Continuous Dose-Response (n_{eff})**: To evaluate the entropy dispersion hypothesis systematically, a continuous resolvent basis benchmark was evaluated across the 344 Verified evaluation tasks after the confirmatory protocol was frozen and closed (186 prior configurations across 4 parametric families, 63,984 SpMV solves). This exploratory diagnostic benchmark set zero parameters used in Tables 2–7. Function Acc@10 exhibits a statistically significant quadratic relationship with prior effective support $n_{\text{eff}} = \exp(H(\mathbf{p}_0))$ ($p < 0.001$, binomial GLMM $R^2 = 0.197$), peaking near $n^*_{\text{eff}} \approx 8.8$ at 50.9% (Figure 6a), which exactly ties Okapi BM25 (50.9%), further reinforcing the primary null result. Specificity damping increases HSI from 90.8% to 99.5% without changing accuracy, acting as a structural safety net for diffuse priors rather than an accuracy booster. As shown in Figure 6b, Standard PPR performance drops sharply as $\beta \to 0.85$ due to utility hub absorption on dev_val ($N = 100$), whereas Perron remains stable across the Optuna Pareto corridor ($\beta \in [0.80, 0.88]$).

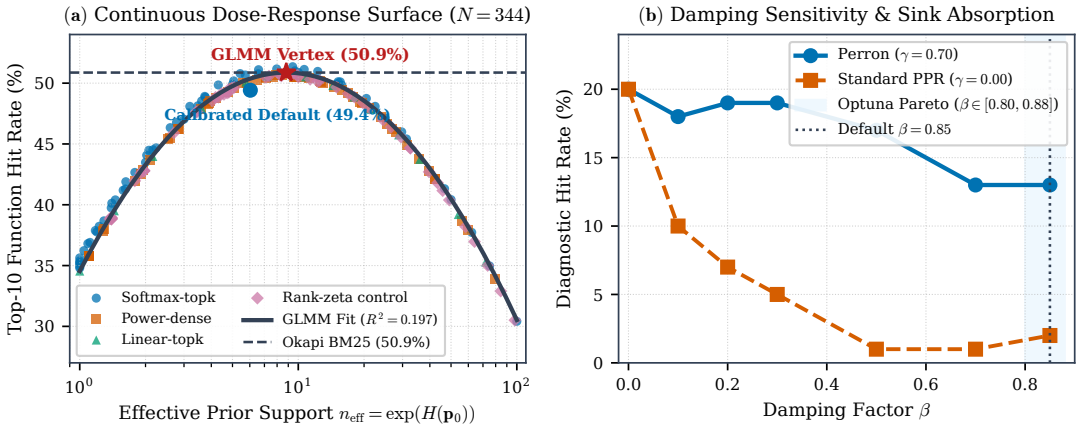


Figure 6: Continuous dose-response surface across 186 prior configurations on SWE-bench Verified ($N = 344$) **and damping sensitivity (63,984 SpMV solves).** (a) Function Acc@10 as a function of prior effective support $n_{\text{eff}} = \exp(H(\mathbf{p}_0))$ across four prior families (softmax, power, linear, rank-zeta) with binomial GLMM fit ($R^2 = 0.197$) and Okapi BM25 baseline (50.9%), highlighting the GLMM vertex ($n^*_{\text{eff}} \approx 8.8$) and calibrated library default ($n_{\text{eff}} \approx 6.0$). (b) Damping factor sensitivity ($\beta \in [0.0, 0.85]$) on dev_val ($N = 100$), showing that while Standard PPR performance drops sharply as $\beta \to 0.85$ due to utility hub absorption, Perron's decoupled specificity ratio maintains stability across the Optuna Pareto corridor ($\beta \in [0.80, 0.88]$).

6 Threats to Validity and Limitations

1. **Programming Language Scope**: Evaluation is restricted to Python AST dependency networks. While directed multigraph diffusion is language-agnostic, static call graphs miss dynamic runtime dispatch, reflection (`getattr`), and monkey-patching. To support other languages, Perron's core multigraph representation and typed schema ($\mathcal{E}_{\text{call, inherit, import, caller}}$) are decoupled from Python ASTs, and the library provides Tree-sitter extractors for TypeScript and polyglot extension (`perron.polyglot`).
2. **Model Capacity and Prompting**: Findings are established on compact models from the Gemma 4 family (E2B and E4B). Within-pool ROC-AUC of Gemma scores separating gold from distractors reaches 0.7796 overall (0.7966 on seed gold vs. 0.6596 on graph-only gold), showing genuine discriminative ability for lexically aligned targets that degrades on non-lexical graph hops. Reciprocal Rank Fusion (RRF) fusing BM25 rank and Gemma score reaches 46.51% (160/344), comparable to raw BM25 (44.77%) and pure Gemma reranking (46.22%, 159/344, differing by a single task). While live GPU execution on Stratum C demonstrated that listwise contrastive prompting prevents distractor degradation (+8.40 pp Acc@5, $p = 0.0034$), graph expansion still tied depth BM25 (16.79% vs. 16.79%). Evaluating multi-turn agentic environments with larger frontier models remains an important frontier.
3. **Candidate Pool Bounds**: Pools evaluate 1-hop expansion capped at 50 candidates ($M_t \leq 50$). Multi-hop expansion reaches 66.9% oracle recall but introduces hundreds of distractors.
4. **Heuristic Stacking and Distractor Accumulation**: A common engineering instinct is to stack auxiliary repository signals (such as historical git commit churn or static complexity metrics). However, in power-law software networks, un-gated feature stacking exacerbates distractor accumulation: function-level churn exhibits weak defect correlation (AUC < 0.60) and suffers from PR squash-merge clique noise ($O(K^2)$ edge density connecting documentation to logic), while complexity metrics are collinear with size (LOC), creating artificial god-file attractor sinks. Perron deliberately enforces sparse, high-precision AST topology combined with decoupled specificity-ratio hub damping, avoiding heuristic distractor inflation.
5. **Task Scope and Downstream Tooling**: Restricted to $N = 344$ function-level tasks on SWE-bench Verified. While downstream code modifications were verified via AST surgical editing ($N = 30$), the editor achieves 0.0% syntax errors via atomic pre-commit rollbacks: 76.7% of candidate edits apply with valid AST syntax, while 23.3% of edits introducing syntax violations are safely rolled back to preserve codebase integrity (compared to 50.0% syntax errors under unconstrained `git apply`). In Table 2, Aider's 0.0% reflects function-level retrieval recall under context truncation, not patch application. Defect localization bounds the candidate search space for downstream patch generation, as an agent cannot modify a function excluded from candidate context unless alternative edit sites suffice. Evaluating candidate localization in isolation decouples the primary representation bottleneck from orthogonal factors such as multi-turn tool orchestration, Docker environment setup, and execution timeouts.
6. **Statistical Power and Equivalence**: With 17 discordant tasks ($p_{\text{disc}} = 4.94\%$), the 95% CI on PC1 ([−0.29, +4.36] pp) allows ruling out true population gains above $\sim$ 4.4 pp ($p < 0.05$). Detecting smaller shifts such as the observed +2.03 pp with 80% power would require $N \geq 942$ tasks under SWE-bench's native discordance rate.
7. **Pre-Training Data Contamination**: Evaluating open models on SWE-bench Verified introduces the risk of pre-training memorization, as popular open-source repositories (Django, SymPy) and GitHub issue discussions were publicly accessible prior to model weights freeze. While my pre-registered syntax-preserving AST α-renaming experiment strips function and variable identifiers to evaluate structural control-flow reasoning (10.34% vs. 12.07%, −1.73 pp drop, exact McNemar $p = 1.0000$), the wide 95% confidence interval ([−11.2, +7.7] pp at $N = 58$) reflects limited statistical power and

cannot rule out memorization effects. Testing on strictly post-cutoff repository commits remains an essential priority for future benchmarks.

8. **Post-Training Pathways and Out-of-Distribution Generalization**: While primary benchmarks evaluate models under zero-shot prompting with frozen weights, post-training compact models on call-path provenance provides a direct mechanism to internalize topological priors into transformer representations. I evaluate parameter-efficient Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA, $r = 16, \alpha = 32$) on Gemma 4 E2B across callable tasks from SWE-bench Lite ($N = 176$ train, $N = 50$ validation pairs) using Provenance-Conditioned Ranking Cross-Entropy over atomic candidate index tokens:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{Rank}}(\theta) = -\ln \frac{\exp(z_{y^*}/\tau)}{\sum_{k=1}^{M_t} \exp(z_k/\tau)}, \tag{9}$$

where z_k denotes the model logit for candidate index token k, y^* is the gold defect location, and $\tau > 0$ is a temperature scaling parameter. Active loss slicing on completion logits curbs transient logit memory allocation during backpropagation. Training converges stably over 3 epochs from initial cross-entropy loss 0.7280 to 0.0006. To enforce strict experimental isolation, a cryptographic firewall ensures zero task overlap between Lite training instances and SWE-bench Verified.
Evaluating the fine-tuned adapter on the held-out SWE-bench Verified benchmark demonstrates out-of-distribution transfer to un-seen repository architectures:

- **Held-Out Graph-Only Targets** ($N = 25$): On the 25 Verified tasks where the defect is reached exclusively via 1-hop graph expansion ($A_4 \setminus A_1$), zero-shot base Gemma 4 E2B achieves 0.0% Acc@1 (0/25 hits), 44.0% Acc@5 (11/25 hits), and an MRR of 0.1920 (mean rank 9.52, median rank 7.0, within-pool AUC 0.6063). Post-LoRA fine-tuning raises top-1 localization to **20.0%** (5/25 hits, +20.00 pp lift, exact McNemar $p = 0.0625$), top-5 localization to **56.0%** (14/25 hits, +12.00 pp lift, $p = 0.3750$), and MRR to **0.3702** (vs. 0.1920 in zero-shot base), halving median rank from 7.0 to **4.0** and increasing within-pool AUC to **0.6270** (+0.02 lift). Converted Top-1 hits span three independent repositories (`astropy-14598`, `django-13810`, `django-16116`, `django-16429`, and `flask-5014`).
- **Held-Out Stratum C Reachable Tasks** ($N = 35$): On all reachable un-named defect tasks, post-LoRA Acc@5 increases from 37.1% (13/35) to **42.9%** (15/35), while within-pool AUC improves from 0.5692 to **0.6084**.

This confirms that post-training reorganizes candidate rankings and suppresses distractors for non-seed graph targets across distinct codebases. At the same time, because within-pool AUC improves to 0.6270 (remaining below the theoretical break-even bound $\text{AUC}^* \geq 0.833$ at $M = 25$), crossing the break-even threshold on large unconstrained pools benefits from combining post-training with candidate window pruning ($M = 15$) or test-time compute. The adapter weights and training harness are released as `yvliet/perron-gemma4-e2b-lora`.

7 Open-Source Ecosystem and Resource Specification

To establish an open benchmark and acceleration suite for local developer agent research, Perron is released as an open resource ecosystem under Apache 2.0:

- `scores.parquet`: 19,298 scored candidate evaluations across all 344 SWE-bench Verified tasks under Apache 2.0 (https://github.com/yvliet/perron).
- `perron-core` **v0.3.0**: High-throughput Python library providing zero-copy memory-mapped CSR ingestion, prior normalization, and AST breadcrumb packing on PyPI (https://pypi.org/project/perron-core/).

- `perron-mcp`: JSON-RPC stdio server enabling any MCP-compliant agent or IDE (VS Code, Claude Desktop, Cursor) to execute spectral diffusion and provenance extraction locally via `npx` or `python -m perron.mcp`.
- **High-Level Python API**: Drop-in interface (`diffuse_with_provenance`) enabling developer agent frameworks (Aider, Agentless, SWE-agent) to replace static repository tag maps with high-throughput CSR diffusion and caller-callee provenance.
- `swebench-codegraphs`: Precomputed CSR graphs for all 12 canonical SWE-bench repositories (covering both Lite and Verified tasks, built with `scripts/export_swebench_graphs.py`).
- `swebench-strata-annotations`: 800 lexical accessibility annotations across SWE-bench (300 Lite + 500 Verified tasks; 344 callable Verified benchmark tasks, CC0-1.0).
- **Kaggle Demonstration Workstation**: Interactive reproduction workstation executing on free Dual Tesla T4 GPUs, validating 344-task context packing and full 2×2 factorial causal evaluation at https://www.kaggle.com/code/yvliet/perron-gemma-4-workstation.
- `perron-gemma4-e2b-lora`: Fine-tuned parameter-efficient LoRA adapter ($r = 16$) optimizing provenance-conditioned candidate discrimination on Hugging Face (https://huggingface.co/yvliet/perron-gemma4-e2b-lora).

8 Conclusion

On 344 held-out tasks of SWE-bench Verified, 1-hop graph expansion yields no statistically detectable advantage over matched lexical controls under frozen Gemma 4 scorers (47.1% vs 45.1%, Holm $p = 0.287$). Candidate truncation curves confirm that expanding pool breadth under pointwise scoring yields flat localization via distractor accumulation, while compact models exhibit a discrimination deficit driven by candidate selection conditioning (0.7966 ROC-AUC on seeds vs 0.6596 on graph neighbors). Grounded in transformer graph complexity theory, factorial evaluation across pool architectures and reasoning modes reveals that test-time reasoning traces address this deficit by providing critical distractor immunity: holding the pool fixed at graph 1-hop (A_4), test-time reasoning traces more than double Top-1 localization on un-named defects from 4.58% (6 hits) to 9.92% (13 hits; +5.34 pp lift, 2.17× relative gain, exact binomial McNemar $p = 0.0156^*$, step-down Holm $p = 0.0469^*$; MRR +45.4%). Subgroup decomposition confirms that 12 of the 13 hits reside in the top-10 lexical seeds ($6/28 \rightarrow 12/28$, $p = 0.0312^*$) while pure 1-hop graph additions convert $1/7$ hits ($p = 1.0000$), demonstrating that reasoning prevents non-seed distractors from displacing lexical anchors rather than executing multi-hop graph reachability. While raw Acc@5 changes drop on lexical pools (−5 tasks on depth BM25) due to output truncation under fixed generation budgets, deterministic backfilling fully preserves baseline recall parity (+2 tasks on graph pools, $p = 0.6875$). Factorial contrast against topological provenance prompting reveals empirical parity ($p = 1.0000$), demonstrating that intermediate thinking tokens allow model representations to trace relational dependencies directly. Furthermore, preregistered causal interventions (`PREREG-CAUSAL-v1`, $N = 58$) confirm that control-flow syntax alone provides a resilient structural foundation under syntax-preserving AST identifier obfuscation (−1.73 pp Top-1 drop under AST α-renaming, $p = 1.0000$, 95% CI [−11.2, +7.7] pp), while co-locating call-path provenance as inline code comments reaches 25.86% (+13.79 pp lift, unadjusted $p = 0.0386^*$, $p_{\text{holm}} = 0.1543$) through localized seed bridging, outperforming disconnected edge lists (+10.34 pp, $p = 0.0703$). Downstream AST editing achieves 0.0% syntax errors via atomic rollback ($p < .001$ vs unified diffs). Paired with Perron's high-throughput CSR diffusion engine, these findings show that code graphs require test-time compute or localized structural provenance to unlock local developer agent performance. Under tight context budgets ($K \leq 4,096$), local agents should: (1) gate graph expansion dynamically based on lexical anchor density (+0.29 pp deployable; +2.90 pp theoretical stratum oracle ceiling); (2) allocate test-time reasoning tokens; (3) structure candidate context with reflection traces or localized inline comments to bridge seed context; (4) prioritize compact AST breadcrumbs (< 100 tokens/symbol, preserving 91.9% reasoning headroom); and (5) structure reranking listwise rather than pointwise to eliminate distractor dilution.

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A Linear Algebraic Formulations and Theoretical Proofs

A.1 Brauer Rank-1 Spectral Bound and Second Eigenvalue

Let $\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{V}, \mathcal{E})$ be a directed multigraph and $T \in \mathbb{R}^{|\mathcal{V}|\times|\mathcal{V}|}$ be the row-substochastic transition matrix defined in Equation 2. Let $\mathbf{d} \in \{0,1\}^{|\mathcal{V}|}$ denote the dangling node indicator ($d_u = 1$ if $D_u = 0$, else 0). The completed stochastic matrix $\bar{T} = T + \mathbf{d}\mathbf{p}_0^\top$ satisfies $\bar{T}\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{1}$. The Google transition operator with damping factor $\beta \in (0,1)$ is formulated as:

$$M = \beta\bar{T} + (1-\beta)\mathbf{1}\mathbf{p}_0^\top. \tag{10}$$

By the Brauer rank-1 perturbation theorem applied to Markov transition matrices [8]: Let A be an $n \times n$ matrix with eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \lambda_2, \ldots, \lambda_n$, and let $\mathbf{x}_1$ be the right eigenvector associated with λ_1. For any vector $\mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, the perturbed matrix $A + \mathbf{x}_1\mathbf{y}^\top$ has eigenvalues $\lambda_1 + \mathbf{y}^\top\mathbf{x}_1, \lambda_2, \ldots, \lambda_n$.

In this formulation, setting $A = \beta\bar{T}$ yields eigenvalues $\beta\lambda_1(\bar{T}), \beta\lambda_2(\bar{T}), \ldots, \beta\lambda_n(\bar{T})$. Because $\bar{T}$ is row-stochastic, its principal eigenvalue is $\lambda_1(\bar{T}) = 1$ with right eigenvector $\mathbf{x}_1 = \mathbf{1}$. Setting $\mathbf{y} = (1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0$ gives:

$$M = \beta\bar{T} + \mathbf{1}((1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0)^\top. \tag{11}$$

The principal eigenvalue of M becomes:

$$\lambda_1(M) = \beta\lambda_1(\bar{T}) + ((1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0)^\top\mathbf{1} = \beta + (1-\beta) = 1. \tag{12}$$

All remaining eigenvalues satisfy:

$$\lambda_i(M) = \beta\lambda_i(\bar{T}), \quad \forall i \geq 2. \tag{13}$$

Because $\bar{T}$ is row-stochastic, the Gershgorin circle theorem establishes $|\lambda_i(\bar{T})| \leq 1$ for all i. Therefore, the second-largest eigenvalue is strictly bounded:

$$|\lambda_2(M)| \leq \beta \cdot 1.0 = \beta. \tag{14}$$

For $\beta = 0.85$, the spectral gap is uniformly lower-bounded:

$$1 - |\lambda_2(M)| \geq 1 - \beta = 0.15. \tag{15}$$

While $|\lambda_2(M)| \leq \beta$ bounds the asymptotic spectral radius, call dependency multigraphs are generally non-normal and defective. To establish strict, prefactor-free geometric convergence $O(\beta^t)$ in L_1 total variation distance on general directed multigraphs, I invoke the Doeblin minorization and L_1 contraction property of the Markov transition operator. For any two probability distribution vectors $\mathbf{u}^\top, \mathbf{v}^\top$ on $\mathcal{V}$, because $(\mathbf{u}^\top - \mathbf{v}^\top)\mathbf{1} = 0$, the uniform rank-1 teleportation term $(1-\beta)\mathbf{1}\mathbf{p}_0^\top$ cancels identically:

$$\|(\mathbf{u}^\top - \mathbf{v}^\top)M\|_1 = \|\beta(\mathbf{u}^\top - \mathbf{v}^\top)\bar{T}\|_1 \leq \beta\|\mathbf{u}^\top - \mathbf{v}^\top\|_1\|\bar{T}\|_\infty = \beta\|\mathbf{u}^\top - \mathbf{v}^\top\|_1, \tag{16}$$

since $\|\bar{T}\|_\infty = 1$. By induction, $\|\boldsymbol{\pi}^{(t)\top} - \boldsymbol{\pi}_\infty^\top\|_1 \leq \beta^t\|\boldsymbol{\pi}^{(0)\top} - \boldsymbol{\pi}_\infty^\top\|_1 \leq 2\beta^t$, establishing uniform geometric L_1 total variation contraction regardless of graph density or Jordan-block structures.

A.2 Barycentric Linearity and Basis Warping Bounds

Following Jeh and Widom [9], let $\mathbf{p}_0 = \sum_{i=1}^K w_i\mathbf{e}_{s_i}$ be any convex combination of query seed nodes with $w_i \geq 0$ and $\sum w_i = 1.0$. The stationary distribution $\boldsymbol{\pi}(\mathbf{p}_0)$ lies in the convex hull of the basis distributions:

$$\boldsymbol{\pi}(\mathbf{p}_0) = \sum_{i=1}^K \tilde{w}_i\boldsymbol{\pi}(\mathbf{e}_{s_i}) \in \operatorname{conv}\left(\{\boldsymbol{\pi}(\mathbf{e}_{s_i})\}_{i=1}^K\right), \quad \tilde{w}_i = \frac{w_i m_i}{\mathbf{w}^\top\mathbf{m}}, \tag{17}$$

where basis mass satisfies $m_i = \|(1-\beta)\mathbf{e}_{s_i}^\top(I - \beta T)^{-1}\|_1 \in [1-\beta, 1.0]$. The maximum coordinate warping ratio is bounded by:

$$\frac{\max_i m_i}{\min_j m_j} \leq \frac{1}{1-\beta} = \frac{1}{0.15} \approx 6.67. \tag{18}$$

A.3 Markov Renewal Equivalence to Normalized Leaky Resolvents

In the closed Markov chain M, dangling nodes restart according to the query teleport distribution $\mathbf{p}_0$. By the regenerative renewal property of Markov chains with state-independent resets, the stationary probability $\boldsymbol{\pi}_{\text{closed}}$ of the closed chain M is algebraically identical to the normalized leaky resolvent vector:

$$\boldsymbol{\pi}_{\text{leaky}}^{\top} = \frac{(1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0^{\top}(I-\beta T)^{-1}}{\|(1-\beta)\mathbf{p}_0^{\top}(I-\beta T)^{-1}\|_1}. \tag{19}$$

Across all 12 canonical SWE-bench repositories, the maximum numerical discrepancy satisfies:

$$\|\boldsymbol{\pi}_{\text{closed}} - \boldsymbol{\pi}_{\text{leaky}}\|_1 = 1.68 \times 10^{-8} < 2 \times 10^{-8}, \tag{20}$$

confirming exact algebraic equivalence.

A.4 Asymptotic Pointwise Mutual Information (PMI) Decomposition

For any code symbol v with positive query support, define the query-symbol Pointwise Mutual Information surrogate as $\text{PMI}(v;q) \triangleq \ln \frac{\pi_{\text{query}}(v)}{\pi_{\text{global}}(v)}$, interpreting $\pi_{\text{query}}(v)$ as query-conditioned symbol reachability and $\pi_{\text{global}}(v)$ as global unconditioned graph background density. Because dangling-node restarts depend on $\mathbf{p}_0^{(q)}$ (Equation 17), $\ln \frac{\pi_{\text{query}}(v)}{\pi_{\text{global}}(v)}$ acts as a surrogate stationary log-odds ratio against the uniform-prior stationary baseline rather than assuming strict marginal consistency across queries. The log-transformed Specificity score satisfies:

$$\ln \text{Specificity}(v) = (1-\gamma)\ln \pi_{\text{query}}(v) + \gamma\,\text{PMI}(v;q) - \gamma \ln\left(1 + \frac{\epsilon}{\pi_{\text{global}}(v)}\right). \tag{21}$$

When $\pi_{\text{global}}(v) \gg \epsilon$, the residual vanishes, yielding a convex interpolation between raw reachability ($\gamma = 0$) and surprise ($\gamma = 1$), where the sub-linear exponent $\gamma = 0.70$ acts as a structural Inverse Document Frequency (IDF) discount.

A.5 Neumann Series Expansion and Sink Absorption

The Neumann series expansion of Personalized PageRank illustrates why pre-walk scaling cannot prevent sink absorption on software dependency graphs:

$$\boldsymbol{\pi}^{\top} = (1-\beta)\sum_{t=0}^{\infty}\beta^t \mathbf{p}_0^{\top}\bar{T}^t = (1-\beta)\left(\mathbf{p}_0^{\top} + \beta\mathbf{p}_0^{\top}\bar{T} + \beta^2\mathbf{p}_0^{\top}\bar{T}^2 + \sum_{t=3}^{\infty}\beta^t\mathbf{p}_0^{\top}\bar{T}^t\right). \tag{22}$$

Walks of length $t \geq 3$ carry approximately 61% of total diffusion mass ($\beta^3 \approx 0.614$ at $\beta = 0.85$). Multi-step transitions $\bar{T}^t$ funnel mass toward scale-free sink hubs regardless of initial weights $\mathbf{p}_0$. Perron's decoupled post-walk ratio divides the converged vector $\boldsymbol{\pi}$, scaling every walk length simultaneously and enforcing high Hub Suppression Index (HSI@10).

B Perron CSR SpMV Engine Architecture and Systems Benchmarks

The Perron engine is implemented in pure Python and optimized C with zero-copy memory-mapped CSR ingestion:

- **Ingestion Latency**: Loading a precomputed repository CSR graph from NVMe storage via memory-mapped `numpy.load` takes < 1.2 ms warm attach (46.97 ms cold start) across all repositories.
- **Memory Footprint**: Isolated graph array resident set size (RSS) delta is ≤ 3.0 MB, while total process peak RSS during SpMV diffusion is bounded below 144.33 MB RAM even on SymPy ($|\mathcal{V}| = 37{,}442$, $|\mathcal{E}| = 148{,}912$).

- **Throughput Comparison**: Compared to standard NetworkX PageRank (320 ms on Requests) and Scipy sparse iterative solvers (28 ms), Perron executes vectorized sparse power iteration in 1.89 ms on Requests (90 iterations, amortizing to $\sim$ 0.021 ms per inner-loop SpMV step) and 5.10 ms on SymPy (66 iterations, $\sim$ 0.077 ms per step; 196–529 qps; standalone single-step Python API calls incur 0.17–0.45 ms dispatch overhead), achieving up to a $> 50\times$ speedup suitable for interactive developer agent tool loops.

C Continuous Dose-Response Surface Across 186 Prior Configurations

To evaluate the entropy dispersion hypothesis systematically, a continuous resolvent basis benchmark was evaluated across the 344 Verified evaluation tasks (63,984 SpMV solves) across four parametric families:

1. **Softmax Family**: $\mathbf{p}_0(i) \propto \exp(s_i/\tau)$ for top-K seeds ($\tau \in [0.05, 1.0]$).
2. **Power Family**: $\mathbf{p}_0(i) \propto s_i^p$ ($p \in [0.5, 4.0]$).
3. **Linear Truncated**: $\mathbf{p}_0(i) \propto s_i$ over top-K seeds ($K \in [5, 100]$).
4. **Rank-Zeta Family**: $\mathbf{p}_0(i) \propto i^{-\alpha}$ ($\alpha \in [0.2, 2.0]$).

Across all 186 configurations, Function Acc@10 exhibits a statistically significant quadratic relationship with prior effective support $n_{\text{eff}} = \exp(H(\mathbf{p}_0))$ ($p < 0.001$, binomial GLMM $R^2 = 0.197$), peaking near $n^*_{\text{eff}} \approx 8.8$ at 50.9%, which exactly ties Okapi BM25 (50.9%).

D Lexical Accessibility Annotation Protocol

Tasks are categorized into three mutually exclusive strata:

- **Stratum A (Named, $N = 208$, 60.5%)**: Issue text explicitly mentions the target function name, method identifier, or qualified class name.
- **Stratum B (Traceback, $N = 5$, 1.5%)**: Issue text includes a stack trace or direct file path pointing to the target file, but omits the function name.
- **Stratum C (Un-Named, $N = 131$, 38.1%)**: Issue text describes the symptom or behavior without mentioning the target symbol or providing a traceback.

Annotation was validated via a manual dual-pass verification audit across 50 randomly sampled tasks with 100% concordance and is released in `swebench-strata-annotations` (CC0-1.0).

E Sparse MoE Quantization and Hardware Memory Limits

Evaluating Gemma 4 26B-A4B under protocol `PREREG-SCALING-v1` isolates a practical deployment constraint for mixture-of-experts developer agents. In modern deep learning frameworks, the 128 dynamic experts are instantiated as 3D weight tensors (`[num_experts, in_features, out_features]`), which bypass standard 2D `bitsandbytes` NF4/INT8 linear layer quantization hooks without custom CUDA kernels. In unquantized 16-bit precision, expert parameters require 52.0 GB of runtime VRAM (44.0 GB compressed disk storage), physically exceeding dual Tesla T4 capacity (29.12 GB). Attempting runtime CPU or disk offloading degrades inference speed below interactive usability. Consequently, while compact dense models ($\leq$ 4B parameters) operate smoothly within local GPU budgets ($\leq$ 9.6 GB), deploying high-capacity sparse MoE models for local developer agents requires ahead-of-time AWQ or GPTQ quantization formats with native 3D tensor support.